
The Name That Cannot Be Said

A Dialogue in Four Nocturnal Movements
in the Library of the Badia Cavensis
Dioecesis Amalphiae · Anno Domini mcccxxvii

Pasquale Camelia

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*This is a work of fiction: historical figures, real places and
real events appear in it in narrative form.*

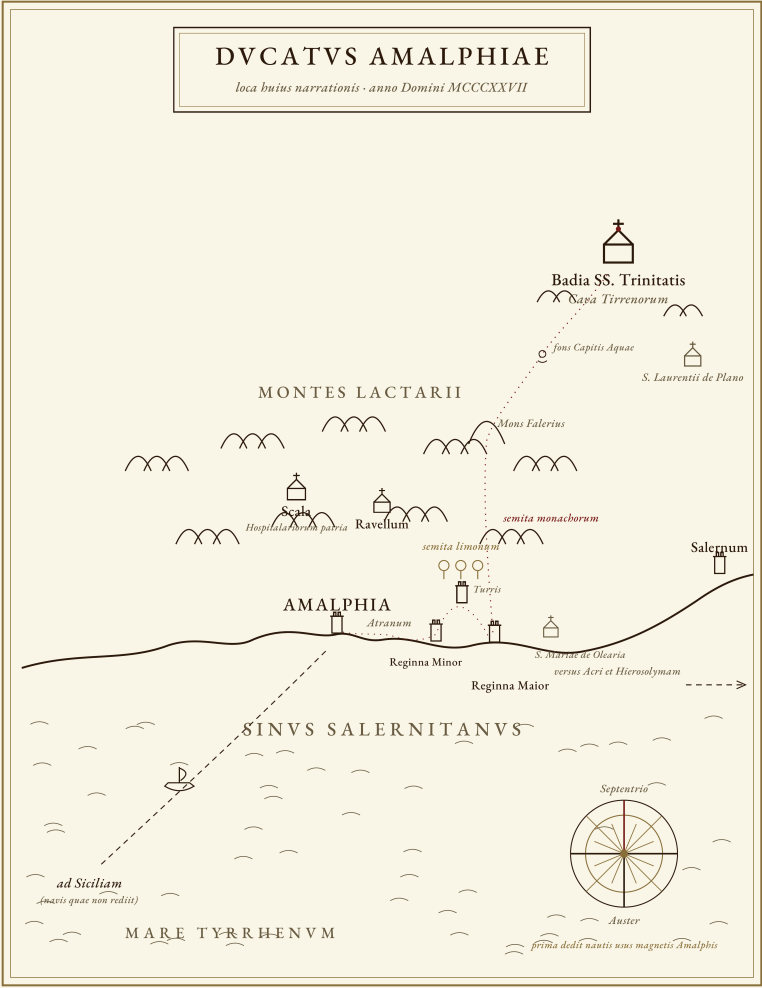
The scientific formulation of the theory behind this book:



The Quantum Gauge Theory of Time — amazon.com/dp/B0H4NWW5J4

TABULA LOCORUM

the Duchy of Amalfi and the Badia of Cava,
as they were at the time of the narrative



Introitus

Antequam esset qui legeret



*Badia SS. Trinitatis Cavensis — the grotto of Saint Alferius,
where everything had its beginning*

In the beginning was the field.

And the field was dust.

Dust of light.

The light vibrated.

*And vibrating it would not lose itself —
it would go on being light.*

So it coalesced.

*It wound in upon itself
at the precise angle
at which descent becomes form
and form becomes memory.*

It became star. Planet. Sea. Rock.

It became seed. Helix. Cell. Thought.

To see

what cannot be named.

*There is a constant engraved in every atom of everything
that exists.*

It is called α . Its value is about $1/137$.

No one knows why it has the value it has.

This book proposes an answer.

*You will not find it in the equations —
the equations are only the way the structure shows itself
to those who can read them.*

*You will find it in the sfusato lemon opened with the
fingers.*

In the sound of a bell ordering itself in the vaults.

*In the restlessness of the heart
that finds no peace
because it carries within it the signature of something
it cannot contain.*

יהוה

written in the rock before there was anyone to read it

Letter	Name	Value	Form	Structure
י	Yod	10	point	Total ingathering. Before anything happens.
ה	Hei	5	open roof	One side remains open. What does not pass does not vanish.
ו	Vav	6	hook	The channel that connects without belonging to either.
ה	Hei	5	open roof	Same glyph. Same value. But it is already after. The difference is time.

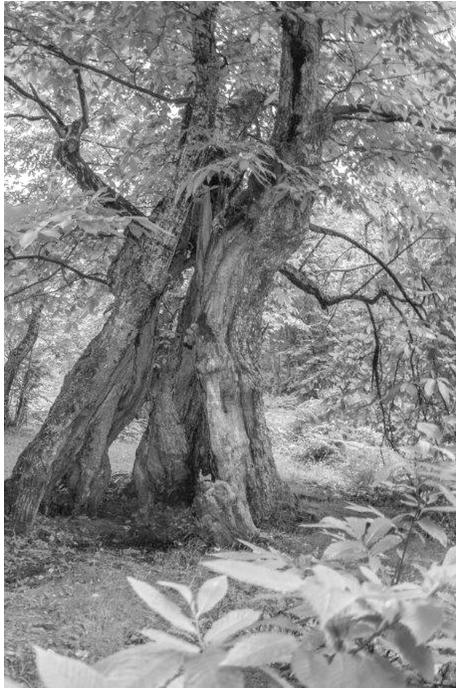
like the four movements of a Mass

like the four bases of DNA

like the four figures of light in space

Kyrie

In quo tempore et loco



*The chestnut groves — a single stock, two trunks:
the root descending as far as the branch rises*

Kyrie

In quo tempore et loco

I, Urso of Amalfi, novice at my master's side, will write here what happened that night, though even today I do not know with certainty whether I truly understood or only believed that I understood.

It was the Badia of the Most Holy Trinity of Cava de' Tirreni, Diocese of Amalfi, founded by the blessed Alferius three hundred and sixteen years before. Late November, Anno Domini mccccxvii. The eleventh month. The month of the border — neither the end nor the beginning, but the boundary between the two. Advent at the gates.

The night's cold was taut as chestnut wood. The leaves had fallen from the chestnut groves of the Badia. On the branches there remained that bronze colour November leaves as its signature before it is gone.

I thought of the branches. How they stretch toward the sky year after year, according to a measure that is not chosen but followed. The root descending as far as the branch rises. The leaf that seeks the light with the same force with which the root seeks water in the dark.

Growing is always a palindrome. As much toward the light as toward the hypogean roots — what is never

seen, what no one will ever observe, and what grounds all that is visible.

That night I rose for Vigils before the signal.

The cloister was empty. No wind. The cold held even the lamp's flame still.

I passed along the flank of the church. Dark. Mute. One more hour, and the brothers would fill it — the Rule requires that Vigils end with the *supplicatio litaniae*: Kyrie eleison, three times three, nine invocations like nine steps.

And I noticed that the supplication had already begun.

Not in the church. In me. It was rising on its own, syllable by syllable, as water rises in a well — *Kyrie eleison, Christe eleison, Kyrie eleison* — without my having decided to pray. I had known it by heart since I was ten years old. But that night, for the first time, I asked myself what we were asking for.

Eleison. Have mercy.

Mercy for what? Not for sins only — for those there is confession, which has its own words. This is another question, more ancient, asked in the dark before dawn: have mercy on what passes. On what may be lost in the passage.

The cry of everything that fears it will not arrive.

Nine times. Because once is not enough — because the suppliant knows that almost everything, in the world, does not arrive.

I stopped at the lavabo — the bronze basin where we wash our hands before entering the church. In the dark, the water seemed stone.

Seemed.

I brought the lamp closer. The surface trembled. A trembling smaller than anything I knew how to name — not waves: a veil of motion, like the skin of a sleeping animal. I held my breath, because I thought it was my breath. It trembled. I laid my hands on the rim to still it, and it was worse: I felt my pulse pass into the bronze and enter the water. It trembled with my blood.

I understood then that I was not trying to still the water. I was trying to still the world.

So the schools taught, reading Boethius: there is a music of the spheres, and we do not hear it because it never falls silent — what has never begun cannot be heard. I had always taken it for a fine schoolroom maxim. That night, with my hands on the bronze, I felt it as one feels the cold. The world has been sounding since before there was anyone to hear it. Stillness is not among the things that exist.

I wet my palm and ran it along the rim, slowly. I do not know why I did it. Perhaps I only wanted to feel the circle.

The basin sang.

Not loud. A low, round sound that came not from a point but from the whole circle — as if it were not the bronze that sang, but the form. And on the water figures appeared. Still petals, arranged around the centre like a rose. I slowed my hand: the rose came undone and another was born of it, with another number of petals. But not all the figures held. Some formed and remained motionless like carved things. Others trembled, broke, died on the brim before they were born.

I tried to will one — to impose with my hand a middle figure, between two that held. There was no way. The hand gave the motion; the forms were chosen by the circle.

And I noticed something that even today I cannot say without hesitating. The figures that held were those that could not be parted: whole roses, with no seam along which to tear them. Those that carried a fold within them — a way of dividing them into equal parts — broke along that fold. What has in itself a seed of division, divides. What does not, holds.

Then the hand turned more firmly, and the song rose, and what I did not expect happened: the water threw

drops into the air. Tiny spheres that leapt from the circle, shone in the lamplight, fell back. The circle, singing, could not keep the song inside itself. It flung it upward, in the form of spheres.

I withdrew my hand. The song went on — longer than my hand had given. This I remember with certainty, because I stayed to listen to it end: the bronze gave back more than I had given, as if the bottom added something of its own.

I dried my palm on my habit.

Going out, between two arches of the cloister, I raised my eyes.

The November sky was bare. The fixed stars stood in their sphere, the last one — so I had been taught: shells of ether one inside the other, transparent and incorruptible, and the Earth at the bottom of them all like a seed in the fruit. The quintessence, which is neither earth nor water nor air nor fire: the matter of the heavens. And the intelligences that move them, choir above choir, each at its sphere.

I thought of the drops. Each drop had been a small heaven: a sphere flung by the song of a circle.

And the thought came to me reversed — I did not seek it: it found me. The basin had needed no one to set it trembling. Trembling was not its motion: it was its condition. If this is true of bronze, which is

the lowliest of things — what of ether, which is the highest? Perhaps the spheres are not moved. Perhaps they cannot stand still. Perhaps what we call the choir of the intelligences is the name we give, from the bottom of the well, to a necessity that sings.

I made the sign of the cross, for that thought. But I could not bring myself to repent.

And what the commentaries on the Timaeus teach came back to me: that of the five perfect bodies four were given to the elements, and the fifth — the one with pentagonal faces — was kept for the All. Twelve faces, as many as the dwellings of the sun in the year. The body of the quintessence. The five, again: on the water, the rose that had been steadier than all the others — the one the circle had held as one holds a true note — had five petals.

I knew nothing yet. But the sky, that night, no longer seemed to me a vault.

It seemed to me a boundary.



The smallest sign of the alphabet. Almost a point, almost nothing. And yet it is the first letter of the name — the total ingathering, before anything happens. Ten. The complete cycle contracted into a point. Ten

steps, ten pairs, ten decades — everything that exists, reduced to the essential before the projection.

Like William of Ockham before speaking. That dense and precise silence in which everything he was about to say already existed whole within him, waiting only for the moment to come out. He did not prepare the words. He gathered them.



William's thought was like that. Analytic, precise, able to hold together more dimensions of a problem in a single instant — like the copyist who, before setting the quill on the parchment, already has the whole page in his mind — the weight of the black, the proportion of the margins, the exact point where the line will end. The stylus has already scored the guidelines. The hand descends and already knows where it will go. It does not execute. It reveals what is already written in the silence before the writing. But there was always one dimension more that was not calculated, that was not named, that was only felt — like a note that is not in the scale and yet belongs to it, like a chord that is right before one even knows why.

Then the projection took place.

Thought became word. The inside became boundary. And what reached us was already only a part of what had been thought.



That thought had the form of a knotted chestnut staff — straight, with its knots where it had chosen them, memory of every resistance impressed in its form, taut without breaking.

He held it in his right hand, but at times I wondered who was holding whom — whether it was he who held up the wood or the wood that held him up.

A hook. A vertical line with a small crook at the top. The channel that connects heaven and earth without belonging to either.

The staff has always been the sign of those who know. The crozier of the bishop who guides the flock. The staff of Moses that divides the waters — not by force, but by knowledge of where the sea is already disposed to yield.

Six. The number of exchange. Six times ten: sixty — the perfect closure of a circle.



I looked at William.

He was there, standing beside the table, his eyes on the four letters of the Hebrew codex. And I understood — without being able to say it — that he was not *studying* those letters.

He was them.

The name that cannot be said was not written only in that codex. It was written in him.

Like time, which divides and unites.

יהוה

Yod → Hei → Vav → Hei

My master William of Ockham had not slept for two days.

We had come to the Badia to find a man who had disappeared on the route to Sicily. We never found him. We found what he sought.

I found my master in the scriptorium, his satchel still over his shoulder, seated beside three manuscripts aligned on the table with the care of a surgeon laying out his instruments before an operation. He had lit four candles — not one, as would have sufficed — and in his notebook he was copying, from a fourth open codex, numbers I did not recognize.

The first manuscript was a Hebrew codex. On the front board, in black ink on dark leather, two words in Hebrew characters that I could not read:

סֵפֶר הַשֵּׁם

William told me its title without raising his eyes: *Sefer ha-Shem*. The Book of the Name.

Inside, Aramaic annotations in the margins in a paler ink. At the centre of the first page, in bright red ink, four great letters:

יהוה

The second was a Greek codex. On the front board, in gilt letters on red leather:

κατὰ Ἰωάννην

The *Gospel according to John*, in the version received from Constantinople. The Prologue was underlined by an unknown hand.

The third bore a Hebrew title on its board:

סֵפֶר יִצְרָה

Sefer Yetzirah — the Book of Formation — translated into Latin by an anonymous hand of the twelfth century, with notes in Hebrew that corrected the translation.

The fourth was different from the other three. *It had no title. It had no κολοφών*. On the front board: nothing. Bare leather, worn. Inside the cover, blind-stamped in the leather, four marks that I did not recognize as writing:



The parchment was older and thinner, and the text had almost entirely disappeared under layers of later annotations added by different hands at different moments. What remained were the drawings: circles with arrows that turned, double spirals winding around an axis, sequences of numbers in schemes I did not recognize. Beside one of those drawings — a circle with an arrow that never quite closed — a twelfth-century hand had written, in a barely legible Caroline cursive:

figura circuli ignotae originis
— *servatur pro forma* —

The figure preserved for the form. Not for the content.

I did not dare speak at once. I watched my master copy those numbers and waited for him to notice me.

It took a time I do not know how to measure.

At a certain point William stopped writing. He stayed there looking at the three manuscripts in their row. As if he were seeing them for the first time. Or as if he were seeing at last what he had always been trying to see.

— The *Sefer Yetzirah* says, he said quietly, that the world was created with three *sefarim*. Three

instruments. Three modes. *Sefer, sippur, sefer* — number, narration, writing.

He paused.

— I have spent years thinking it was a mystical triad. A symbol.

Then he went back to looking at the notebook. The numbers he had been copying all night.

— But what if it were a structure? **Three constants. Three levels.** One that never closes — irrational, inaccessible, the curvature of what is not seen. One that enters only when the cycle must close — the threshold, the return. And one alone that survives as something that can be read — engraved in every atom, measurable, real.

He stopped.

— I do not know whether the *Sefer Yetzirah* was describing this. I shall never know. But it is the same structure.

He said nothing else. He had no need to. Then he said, without ceasing to write:

— *Sit down, Urso. I have found something that has kept me awake for twenty years. I do not know whether it is a madness or a truth. Perhaps it is the same thing.*

I sat down.

Then, without raising his eyes from the sheets:

— *How many letters are in the name of God?*

— Four, I answered. As everyone knows.

— *And how many fundamental figures does light draw around a fixed centre, in space?*

— I do not know, Master.

— *Four. How many seasons, how many directions of the wind, how many evangelists, how many bases in the seed of life according to the Arab physician I read at Oxford?*

— Four, always four.

— *And do you know why?*

I shook my head.

— *Nor did I, until tonight. Look at these four books. One Hebrew. One Greek. One from a tradition so ancient that no one any longer knows who wrote it. The fourth has no language — only signs. Three languages and one sign. Separated by three millennia. And they are saying the same thing.*

Outside, the wind came down along the flank of the mountain, caressing the sea in an inevitable and harmonious coupling — like two substances of different nature, rock and water, that meet at the *limen* and cannot fail to answer one another, generating something that neither contains on its

own: a wave that belongs neither to the air nor to the limestone, but to the border between the two, and that carries within it the memory of both without belonging to either.

I thought: perhaps the world is made of interfaces. Perhaps everything that exists is at the border between two things that never entirely close.

Gloria

De Nomine in rerum vestigiis

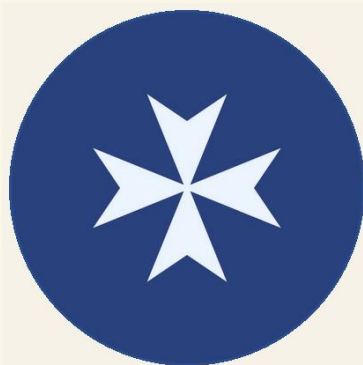


*Ubi terra finit et mare incipit —
ibi structura paret.*

Gloria

I. Laudamus te — De Nomine in rerum vestigiis

Before opening the Hebrew codex, he turned it over in his hands. The parchment was that of the Mezzogiorno — thick, ivory-coloured, ruled with the knife by a steady hand. On the inner board — dark leather, edges worn down to the weave — there was a note in Latin written in an ink turned brown. And above it, branded into the leather: a white cross on a blue field: four arms in the cardinal directions, each with its point forked outward. Eight points in all. Four directions.



*Crux Hospitaliensium Amalphiae,
octo punctis, campo cæruleo.*

*Anno Domini mccxci — captio Accon,
ultima civitas christiana in Terra Sancta.*

I recognized that cross at once. It was the sign of the

Hospitallers of Amalfi — the knights who had founded the hospital of Saint John in Jerusalem even before the First Crusade.

I knew the story.

Saint John of Acre had fallen in 1291 — thirty-six years before. The last Christian city in the Holy Land. The Hospitallers had held out to the end, then fled by sea carrying what they could save: relics, gold, and manuscripts found in the cellars of abandoned houses, written in languages no one read any longer.

Amalfi, at the time of the fall of Acre, was already a shadow of itself. The glorious republic that had ruled the trade of the Mediterranean for two centuries had fallen to the Normans in 1131, then to the Angevins of Naples. Robert of Anjou — the king men called the Wise — had forbidden all trade abroad. The galleys that once carried the goods of Constantinople and of Jerusalem rotted in the arsenals. Amalfi was slowly dissolving, as is the fate of all things that have shone too brightly.

I thought: Amalfi had become the projection of itself. The structure had remained — the stones, the monastic houses, the cross of the Hospitallers, the manuscripts on the shelves. But the original concord was lost in the kernel of time, irrecoverable as what the projection does not transmit. The harbour was still

there. The galleys were no longer. The name was still there. The republic was no longer.

Like the second Hei: same glyph, same value as the first — but it is already after. The difference between the two Hei is what has been lost. And it is time.

And yet Amalfi did not yield. It struggled with itself to change form, to adapt to the new condition in the desperate attempt to resist the dissolving that time brings with it.

The monastic houses merging under a single roof. The paper mills making paper where once the galleys were launched. The Amalfitan Tables — the Tabula de Amalphi, the oldest maritime code in the world, already adopted throughout the Mediterranean — rewritten and updated, as if the laws of the sea could make up for the loss of the sea itself. The assembly of the comites of the coastal towns that met at Atrani under the Angevin officials, to keep alive the form of autonomy even when autonomy had already vanished.

I understood that it was the same thing my master was showing me in those three codices. The boundary that cannot recover the circle builds structures ever more ordered, ever more informed, that mimic consonance without ever reaching it.

Compensation.

It is not weakness. It is the form life takes when the original consonance is lost: the only possible answer to the irrecoverable.

Amalfi was not dissolving. It was becoming a symbol. And symbols last longer than galleys.

Brother Bartolomeo had brought this book to the monastery of San Lorenzo del Piano — one of the oldest monastic houses of the city, founded between the tenth and the eleventh century, dependent on the Badia of Cava. From there the book had climbed the Lattari to the library of the Badia. Thirty-six years of silence on the shelf.

Hic liber inventus est Accone, in domo cuiusdam Iudaei, anno Domini mcccxi, ultima die ante casum civitatis, a fratre Bartholomaeo de Amalfia, milite Hospitalis Sancti Ioannis, qui eum portavit trans mare ne periret.

Dixit frater Bartholomaeus quod liber erat inter alia in cista ferrea sub terra recondita, iuxta scriptum membranaceum his verbis:

“In hoc libro est nomen quod non potest dici. Non propter timorem — propter structuram. Qui legit et intelligit, intelligit etiam cur silentium sit pronunciatio perfecta.”

Ego, frater Bartholomaeus, non intellexi. Sed extraxi librum ex ruinis, quia quod non intellegitur non ideo sine pretio est.

Tradidi eum monasterio Sancti Laurentii de Plano, Amalfi, sub cura abbatiae Cavensis, anno Domini mcccxi, redeunti ab Accon.

Nota donationis, in tabula interiori. Crux Hospitaliensium Amalphiae, octo punctis, campo cæruleo.

Anno Domini mcccxi — captio Accon, ultima civitas christiana in Terra Sancta.

I looked at the cross stamped in the leather.

— Four arms, I said. Eight points.

— Exactly. Now count the cardinal directions — the true directions, the ones that lead far.

— Four, I answered. North, south, east, west.

— And the points on each arm?

— Two per arm. Eight in all.

— And the centre from which everything starts?

— One.

I did the sum without understanding where he wanted to go.

— $4 + 8 + 1 = 13$, I said.

A moment of silence.

— Or else, said William, think of the points as the modes in which the structure opens outward: eight. And of the directions as the levels at which reality can exist in stable form: five. $8 + 5 = 13$.

— Thirteen.

William took the notebook and wrote: $10 + 5 + 6 + 5$.

— The name. Yod, Hei, Vav, Hei. What does it come to?

— Twenty-six.

— Which is?

It took me a moment. — Twice thirteen.

William said nothing. He let the number sit there between us on the table, beside the candles.

$$8 + 5 = 13$$

$2 \times 13 = 26 =$ value of the
Tetragrammaton יהוה

$$\alpha^{-1} + 26 = 137 + 26 = 163$$

163: the largest Heegner number — the most rigid arithmetic structure in all of mathematics

The cross that Pantaleone of Amalfi had given to his knights, pressed into the leather, left engraved the number of the hidden world. *No one could know it.* The structure does not wait to be understood.

II. Qui tollis — De numero qui omnia portat

William stayed looking at the number in the notebook.

163

He did not write it at once. He let it hang in the air for a moment, as if it had to find its place on its own.

Then he said, without raising his eyes:

— Do you know what numbers are, Urso?

— They are instruments, I answered. For counting, for measuring, for calculating.

— No.

The silence that followed was of the kind William rarely used — not for effect, but because he was looking for the right words for something that words struggle to carry.

— Numbers are not instruments. Numbers are the form in which the One knows itself.

I remained silent.

— Before there was anyone to count, the prime numbers existed. Not as concepts. As structure. As the necessary form that reality must have in order to be distinguished from itself. Two was not invented. It is

the condition of distinguishability. The One that looks at itself and finds that there is something that is not it.

— And three? I asked, I do not know why.

— Three is the first number that does not divide without leaving a remainder. The first that resists. The first that has something irreducible. Like $\ker \Pi$ — something that does not pass, that remains whole in the kernel. Three, seven, eleven...

He paused.

*— There is an Indian mathematician — I do not know whether he will ever reach Europe, but his letters circulate among the scholars of Cambridge — who sees numbers as a goddess who writes the formulas on his tongue in dreams. **It is not madness. It is structure.** The abyssus speaks to the boundary in the only language the boundary can receive without breaking: the dream. Intuition. The recognition of something that was never learned.*

— How do I know he has not simply deduced it?

*— Because his formulas are true, said William quietly. And no one knows how to prove them. **He recognized them before proving them.** As one recognizes a melody heard in childhood.*

He rose, walked to the window. The night was still deep.

— Think of this number. 163. It is the largest Heegner number — the only numbers for which the imaginary arithmetic structure is of class one. The most rigid structure there is. There are only nine in all. **Nine**. Not infinitely many. Not many. Nine. As if reality had decided to be rigid at only nine points and fluid at all the others.

— And 163 is the largest?

— Yes. And it is $137 + 26$. The invariant the boundary manages to read (the fine-structure constant, α^{-1}) plus the value of the name ($26 = \text{יהוה}$). **It is not a constructed coincidence**. It is the same structure seen from three directions: physics, mathematics, mysticism. All three arrive at the same number because they start from the same root.

I should have kept silent. A year before, I would have.

— Why add, Master?

He raised his eyes.

— You chose to add. But you could have multiplied, and you would have had another number. Subtracted, and yet another. Give me any two numbers and the operations required, and I will find you a third thing that looks necessary.

He did not answer at once. He laid down his pen — and that gesture, in him, was never surrender: it was weight.

— *Go on, he said.*

I drew breath, because the second was worse.

— *And the twenty-six. It is the Name counted in the Hebrew manner. Count it in Greek, and you will have another value. In Latin, another. It is not the Name that is worth twenty-six, Master: it is you who have read it so that it would be worth twenty-six.*

The silence that followed was long.

— *And the third? he said. You have a third. I can see it.*

— *The third is the simplest. You found the one hundred and sixty-three after knowing the one hundred and thirty-seven and the twenty-six. A thing found afterwards proves nothing.*

I thought he would be angry. He was not. He looked at me as one looks at a new blade: to see whether it cuts.

And then William did something I had never seen him do.

He laughed.

Briefly, almost without sound — like a page turning by itself.

— *Twenty years, he said. Twenty years I have waited for someone to ask me these questions. And it had to be you.*

— *Keep them, he said. All three. Do not let them drop before dawn. If what I show you tonight cannot bear them, it must fall.*

He answered nothing more in words.

William had laid a new parchment on the table. In red ink he was writing in a row, very slowly, nine numbers:

1 2 3 7 11 19 43 67 163

— *Nine, he said. Only nine.*

I counted them with my eyes.

— *What are they, Master?*

— *The Heegner numbers. The only integers for which the arithmetic of imaginary numbers is as rigid as that of the true integers. The field $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{-d})$ has unique factorization only for these nine. There are infinitely many others to try. None works. Only these nine.*

William paused.

— *I cannot prove it, he said. No one breathing today can prove it. But I see it.*

He took the lamp and moved it slowly in a circle around the codex. The candle's shadow turned on the wall — an arrow that rotated with him, always late by the same delay.

— *Everything that turns has its tones, like a bell. And the minimal circle — the smallest ring on which time*

can wind — cannot sound any note whatever. It sounds only its own. Two, three, five, seven, eleven.

— And the other notes? I asked.

— They fall. They do not hold the turn.

Then he did something I did not understand at once. He took a leather strap from his satchel, stretched it between his hands, and gave it a full turn on itself.

— Is it back as it was?

— Yes, I said. Then I looked more closely. The twist was still there, inside the leather.

— No. It carries the turn within it. And there is no way to undo it — except by undoing the turn. But look now.

He gave it a second turn, identical to the first. Then, without ever rotating its ends, he passed the strap around itself — and the twist came undone.

— There are entities, he said quietly, that return to themselves only after two turns. The world is made of them. Everything that has weight is one of these twists, which the minimal circle lifts with it, floor by floor, toward a hall that does not end: a choir where every voice is distinct from every other and no ear can hear them whole. The boundary receives one voice of them at a time.

— And who will prove it, Master?

— *Someone who will come. One they will not believe, at first — because he will be right too soon. It is the fate of those who read the nine numbers: to arrive before the boundary is ready.*

— *gloss of a later hand, twenty-first century —*

Gauss conjectured the list of the nine (Disquisitiones, 1801, art. 303). Kurt Heegner proved it in 1952: the paper was judged incomplete and ignored. Stark and Baker closed the question in 1966–67, recognizing that Heegner had been right — fifteen years before the boundary was ready to read him. The strap is Dirac’s belt trick: the spinor structure, the double cover $SU(2) \rightarrow SO(3)$, the 720° of the return. The tones of the minimal circle are the spectral modes of S^1_χ ; the hall that does not end is the Hilbert space of the boundary.

I took the lamp and brought it close to the parchment. The nine numbers shone like the letters of a psalm.

— *And why are they so important?*

— *Because they are not just any nine, Urso. Look at the first half.*

I put my finger on 1, 2, 3, 7, 11.

— *These are five, I said. The first five.*

— *The five that project onto the boundary. Remove the one and you have $\{2, 3, 7, 11\}$. Add the five and you have $\{2, 3, 5, 7, 11\}$: the admissible modes of the projection,*

the five primes the temporal fibre lets surface. Five is not a Heegner number.

— *Why not?*

— *Because it is the lock-in. The point where unique factorization breaks for the first time. The structure organizes itself on the pure numbers, but rests its weight on the first dissonance. Like a modal scale.*

{1, 2, 3, 7, 11}, {19, 43, 67}, 163

I was looking at the parchment. The first five numbers no longer seemed to me an arithmetic sequence: they seemed five steps.

— *And the other four, Master?*

William drew a circle around {19, 43, 67}.

— *These three are in the kernel. They are not seen. The smallest is nineteen: $19 = 11 + 8$. The last mode of the boundary plus one complete breath. The structure continues beyond the threshold, but no longer in observable form.*

— *And forty-three and sixty-seven?*

William hesitated an instant.

— *I do not know yet. They are inside. I know because they are Heegner and are not admissible. I know because their sum is one hundred and twenty-nine, which divided by thirteen leaves a remainder of minus*

one. I know because nineteen, forty-three and sixty-seven are in arithmetic progression with step twenty-four — three exact breaths. But what they are inside the kernel, Urso, I cannot yet say. The kernel has a structure, and these three are three of its states. Which states, which function, is not yet clear.

I appreciated that he said ‘I do not know’ to me. It was rare in him. I noted it.

And then he set his finger on the last number: 163.

— This is the great one. The largest Heegner. Beyond this, no other integer has imaginary unique factorization. Never again. And this is the number that closes the whole system.

William wrote beneath, slowly:

$$163 = 137 + 26$$

— One hundred and thirty-seven is the pole. The fine-structure constant, α^{-1} . The residue of the projection. The number the boundary manages to read before the rest falls into silence.

— gloss of a later hand, twenty-first century —

The two channels and their product.

The field that crosses the boundary divides into two components that never blur into each other.

ξ — *the longitudinal channel* — is the breath of φ : the internal pressure the bulk exerts toward the boundary, the $SU(2)$ that seeks to transmit itself. But it does not go in a straight line. *It winds.* At every turn it carries with it the signature of the turn before — $\varphi^2 = \varphi + 1$: the structure that grows and recognizes in its own growth its own origin. When it has wound enough, *it observes itself.* And in the moment it observes itself it becomes boundary — becomes η — becomes light. With α , that wound breath grows dense: *the Word is made flesh.* Not because anyone decided it. Because it cannot be otherwise.

η — *the transverse channel* — is the metric: the phase, the observable geometry, the field that carries the form of the world and is read as light, as potential, as measurable space.

$\mathcal{B} \equiv \xi\eta$ is their product: the measure of how far the two channels balance each other. On the physical boundary $\mathcal{B}$ always converges toward the same value — $\mathcal{B}^* = 8 = 2^3$ — regardless of where one starts. *Not by choice. By structure.*

Three symbols. A single breath that winds until it sees itself.

— *And the twenty-six, Master?*

William did not answer at once. He laid the pen beside the notebook and looked at me as one about to say something long awaited.

— *The twenty-six is the dimension of the kernel, taken twice.*

He wrote beneath, slowly:

$$\begin{aligned} 26 &= 2 \times 13 \\ &= 2 \times (5 + 8) \end{aligned}$$

— *Five are the golden modes of the filter — the scale on which the structure organizes itself, each mode in the golden ratio to the one before. The golden memory preserved in the kernel.*

*Eight are the virtues — channels of force that hold matter together without letting themselves be seen. What the schoolmen call virtutes occultae, the kabbalists Sephirot, Dionysius angelic orders. **Not things. Operating powers.***

*Five plus eight, thirteen. And every power exists together with its mirror copy — a right hand, a left hand. Thirteen plus thirteen. **Twenty-six.***

Silence.

— gloss of a later hand, twenty-first century —

The thirteen is not a game of sums. It is the dimension of the kernel that the projection keeps hidden: five scales — rank five, the five admissible primes $\{2, 3, 5, 7, 11\}$ — plus eight degrees of freedom of the forces that hold matter together, $\mathcal{B}_{13} = S_5 \oplus T_8$. The twenty-six is that same thirteen, counted on both Majorana chiralities — the right hand and the left hand of every power.

And its signature is found where physics can measure it: the electroweak mixing angle is $\sin^2 \theta_W = 3/13$. The same thirteen of the kernel, resurfaced on the boundary.

And then I saw what William had built all night:

$$163 = \underbrace{137}_{\alpha^{-1}} + \underbrace{26}_{2 \times 13}$$

The observable pole plus the hidden channels of matter, counted twice for their mirrored chiral form.

*The greatest of the Heegner numbers was not an abstraction. It was **the complete arithmetic index of the physics of the boundary**: what is seen plus what is not seen but holds together what is seen.*

— *And what does this mean, Master?*

William took the parchment. He turned it on its side. He wrote on the edge, very small:

$$163 \equiv 137 \equiv 7 \pmod{13}$$

$$26 \equiv 0 \pmod{13}$$

— *Look.*

I looked.

— *If you measure modulo thirteen — that is, modulo the dimension of the kernel — one hundred and sixty-three and one hundred and thirty-seven give the same remainder. Seven. Their difference, twenty-six, is invisible. It is lost in the measurement.*

A silence.

— *Then ..., I said.*

Then I stopped, because I was about to say something that had never been in my mind to say.

— *Then from the boundary one cannot distinguish the complete reality from its pole. One hundred and sixty-three from one hundred and thirty-seven. The boundary sees seven in both cases. As if they were the same thing.*

— *They are the same thing, Urso. For the boundary.*

William laid down the pen.

— *This is the point. It is not a defect of arithmetic. It is the projection. The non-invertibility of Π written in the theory of numbers. What the abyssus contains — the two copies of the kernel, the twenty-six — the boundary cannot read. Not because it does not know it. Because it is $\equiv 0$. It perishes in the passage.*

Id quod in transitu perit.

III. Cum Sancto Spiritu — De Numero ante omnia

— *But Master. The seven. Why seven, of all numbers?*

William looked at me as if I had struck him.

— *You have asked the right question.*

He rose, walked a few steps. Then came back to the table.

— *Seven is the only one of the five admissible modes that does not tile the plane. $\pi/7$ closes no tiling. The hexagon closes as a Euclidean tiling. The pentagon closes as a golden lock-in — not as a regular Euclidean tiling, but as a fixed point of the projection. And it is the lock-in. The heptagon does not close. It cannot stay on the boundary. It remains inside.*

— *But it is admissible.*

— *Admissible and confined. Its admissibility is arithmetic — $\Pi(7) = 1$, a single prime factor, below the threshold. But its manifestation is geometric. And geometrically, seven cannot surface. It remains in the kernel. And from the kernel it calibrates what is seen. ε_7 : the transport of seven through the structure of the sphere, from the kernel to the boundary. Without the seven, the constant would not have the right value. With the seven inside, it does.*

— *So the seven acts, but is not seen.*

— *And it reveals itself in the modular measure. Look.*

$$137 \equiv 7 \pmod{13}$$

$$163 \equiv 7 \pmod{13}$$

The kernel is thirteen. Seven is the mode of the kernel that signs the boundary. The class in which the pole and the closure collapse is precisely the class of the mode that does not manifest itself.

I sat down.

— *It is as if what holds the boundary together were something the boundary itself cannot see.*

— *Exactly, Urso.*

A pause.

— *What we have found tonight is not a new metaphysics. It is a precise statement. Mod thirteen, the complete reality and its residue are indistinguishable. What perishes in the passage is what makes the passage possible.*

I said nothing.

The four candles burned in their fullness. The wax found the fire, the fire found the wax, and the light stood on the table like something that no longer needed to become. Outside, the wind had changed. It came from the sea.

William did not speak at once. He stayed seated with the parchment before him, looking at the nine numbers as if seeing them for the first time.

Then, without raising his eyes:

— And do you know what is at the centre of all this, Urso?

He took the notebook. On the parchment, beneath the list of the nine Heegner numbers, he slowly traced three vertices — and at the three vertices he wrote, in red, three equations.

$$\begin{array}{c}
 S^1(\tau) = e^{i\tau} \\
 \triangle \\
 \text{ה} \\
 R^{-1} - R = 2\varphi \qquad e^{\pi\sqrt{163}} \approx \varphi^2 \cdot 10^{17}
 \end{array}$$

*R — the infinite ladder of Rogers–Ramanujan,
evaluated on the circle: $q = e^{-2\pi}$*

The circle on the temporal fibre. The golden offset where Rogers–Ramanujan closes — the circle that returns and does not return the same. The maximal

Heegner point where the golden measure returns squared.

Three vertices. One centre. The same voice in three registers.

The continuous and the discrete. The circle that turns and the number that does not divide. The wave and the rock.

I remained silent.

— How does it know? I asked at last. Who put 163 right there?

William looked at me with an expression I did not know how to read.

— No one, he said. The number was already there. Before the circle. Before the projection. Before light and gravity. Before there was anyone to ask why.

The number is the seed of the structure. But the seed is not seen — only the tree that emerges from it is seen. To see the seed one must be the seed. And to be the seed one must cease to be someone who looks.

He lowered his voice.

— That is why Ramanujan dreams. That is why the name is not pronounced. That is why the circle does not close. Because to close would mean ceasing to be the source of everything that does not close.



I said nothing for a long time.

I looked at my hand.

The veins on the back, the skin worn by the cold of the cloisters, the thumbnail slightly crooked since, as a child, I had shut a door too soon. My hand.

And I thought that every chemical bond that held it together carried α^{-1} engraved. That the blood beating in my wrist beat at that number. That the candle's light entered my eyes with the weight of that residue and not of another.

— Master, I said quietly. I did not raise my eyes.

— Yes.

— We are made of the same structure.

William did not answer at once. He stayed looking at the candle as if he too were seeing it for the first time.

— Urso, he said at last, in a voice that was no longer the master's. — We are not *made* of the same structure. *We are the same structure, read from the boundary.*

A pause.

— *Imago Dei*. Not a moral likeness. Not an added dignity. *The same geometry, scaled.* What the kernel

is in the *abyssus*, man is on the boundary. That is why the heart is restless — **because it is the signature that returns to itself.**

I remained silent.

Then I said — and was frightened by what I was about to say:

— But then, Master. If prayer is the signature that returns to itself — we are not praying to someone. We are praying to ourselves.

William looked at me.

It was not the first time that night. But it was the first time my question truly stopped him.

He stayed silent long enough to make me think he would not answer.

Then he said, in a voice that was not the master's — quieter, like one who finds the words in the moment of saying them:

— Yes. And that is why it works.

He added nothing. I asked nothing more.

But much later — years afterwards, with white hair and a knee that gave way on the stairs — I understood the rest of that answer. The self that prays is not the self that made itself. It is the self that was received. It does not pray to itself. It prays to what it is made of. And the difference is everything.



Credo

De fide quae agnitio est



*Arcus repetitus vocem non dissipat.
Colligit.*

Credo

De fide quae agnitio est

The number was still on the notebook. $163 = 137 + 26$.

I looked at the candles, then at the parchment, then at my master. And I felt — for the first time that night — not wonder, but vertigo. The night had filled with entities like a cell with guests: nine rigid numbers, five scales, thirteen channels, twenty-six with their mirror copies, an abyss that no one would ever see, a kernel full of what does not pass.

On the edge of the table, among the inkwells, lay the copyist's rasorium — the short curved blade used to shave the parchment when a word is wrong, or when an ancient page must receive a new writing.

I looked at it a long while before finding the courage.

— Master, I said. At Oxford your pupils repeat a rule of yours. That one must not posit more things than suffice. That it is vain to do with many what can be done with few.

William did not raise his eyes from the notebook.

— Frustra fit per plura quod potest fieri per pauciora, he said. Yes. It is mine.

— Tonight, I said — and my voice trembled, because I was doing to the master what the master did to the world — tonight you have posited an abyss, a kernel,

twenty-six hidden channels, five scales that no one has counted, a seven that acts and is not seen.

I drew breath.

— Where has your razor gone, Master?

William laid down his pen.

He looked at me a long while — and I understood, from the way he did not answer at once, that the question had not offended him. It had reached him.

Then he did something I did not expect. He took the rasorium from the edge of the table and held it on his open palm, as one weighs a coin.

— Do you know what this is for?

— For erasing, I said.

— No. For removing. It is not the same thing.

He went to the fourth manuscript — the one without a title, where the ancient text had almost disappeared under layers of later hands — and held the blade above the page, without touching it.

— The copyist shaves the ink, not the parchment. The parchment must remain: it is what sustains every future writing. If the blade reaches the skin, you have not corrected the page. You have destroyed it.

He turned the blade in the candlelight.

— *This is my razor, Urso. It is not made to deny what sustains. It is made to remove what has been written over it without necessity.*

— *But tonight —*

— *Tonight, count the entities, he said. Not mine. Those of the natural philosophers. A virtue for light. A virtue for weight. One for every motion of the heavens. And for every number they measure, a why that is not there — and every why that is missing is an occult entity, propped in the dark to hold up the account. A mystery for the one hundred and thirty-seven. A mystery for the twenty-six. A mystery for every constant. That, Urso, is the multiplication of entities: *the mystery repeated.**

He laid the blade on the table, gently.

— *Now count mine. *One circle.**

I waited for the rest. It did not come.

— *Only one? I asked.*

— *One. The rest I did not posit. The five I did not choose: it is the only number the turn sustains — try another and it falls. The thirteen I did not posit: it is counted, as one counts fingers. The pole I did not posit: it is the square of the only measure the circle admits. Necessity is not counted among the entities, Urso. *Pluralitas non est ponenda sine necessitate* —*

but what follows by necessity is not plurality. It is the same thing, seen whole.

— And the abyss? I said. The kernel that no one will ever see. Is it not the greatest entity of all?

William took the page of the manuscript between two fingers and lifted it slightly, showing me the reverse.

— This page has two sides. The copyist writes on the recto. The verso is there — you see it — but he did not add it. It is there because the page is one thing with two sides. The kernel is not an entity I add to my list. It is the verso of the projection: if something passes, something does not pass. To deny it — that is what would cost me dear. I would have to posit a miracle for every number that comes out right.

He let the page fall back.

*— I have not betrayed the razor, Urso. I have sharpened it. Until nothing remained but *the last thing that cannot be shaved away*.*

Then he did something I still remember, after all these years, with a precision the rest of the night does not have.

He held out the rasorium to me.

— You keep it, tonight. And every time I show you an entity, ask yourself whether it can be shaved away. If it can, shave it. Even if it is mine.

I took it. It was lighter than I had thought.

*I have done so all my life. Of everything the master showed me that night, some things fell under the blade over the years — correspondences that were only beautiful, numbers that resembled one another without kinship. I shaved them away, as he had asked me. Not the circle. **The circle, the more I shaved it, the cleaner it came out.***

— gloss of a later hand, twenty-first century —

The celebrated formula — *entia non sunt multiplicanda praeter necessitatem* — is not found in Ockham's writings: it was coined three centuries later (John Punch, 1639) and attributed to him. The razor itself is a palimpsest: the later hand writes, the name remains. The authentic formulas are others: *frustra fit per plura quod potest fieri per pauciora; pluralitas non est ponenda sine necessitate*.

The entities of a theory are its axioms, not its theorems. Here the axiom is one — the compact fibre $S^1(\tau)$. Rank five is not posited: it is forced ($F_n = n$ admits only $n \in \{1, 5\}$). The kernel is not an added entity: it is the non-invertibility of Π — the verso of the page. Every constant left without a why is an occult entity; the true reduction is the reduction of the number of mysteries.

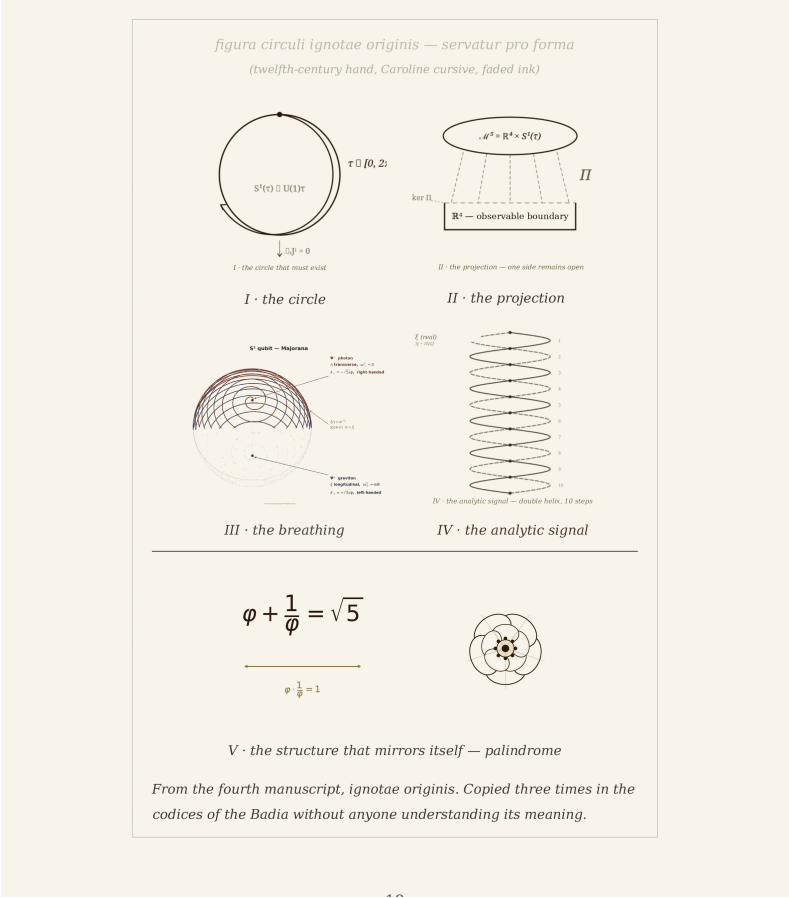
— gloss of a later hand, twenty-first century —

The ladder of registers. The breathing of the sphere has an attractor: $2^3 = 8$. From 11, the first step, one winding of eight rises to 19; three windings to 43; three more to 67. Three recursive registers: $19 + 43 + 67 = 129$. The boundary projects the invariant: $129 + 8 = 137$. The kernel retains the Name: $137 + 26 = 163$ — the last readable number. Five steps, five Heegner numbers: 11, 19, 43, 67, 163. And the thirty-two paths: $4 \times 8 = 32$ — of the first five primes, four are Heegner: 2, 3, 7, 11. The fifth, 5, is not. *It is not a path — it is the walker.*

*At that point William took the fourth manuscript — the one without a title, without *κολοφών* — and opened it before me.*

There was no text. Only figures.

*The first was a circle with an arrow that turned around its edge and never quite closed. Beside it, in a twelfth-century hand: *figura circuli ignotae originis — servatur pro forma.**

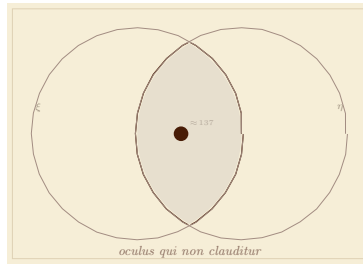


I stayed looking at those figures for a time I do not know how to measure.

I did not understand them. But I recognized them.

As one recognizes a melody heard in childhood: you do not know the title, you do not know the words, and yet something in you already knows how it ends.

The third figure stopped me more than the others.



I recognized it at once.

The form the builders of cathedrals trace around Christ enthroned — the mandorla, the vesica piscis, the space born where two circles interpenetrate.

I had seen it a thousand times. On the portal of the Badia. In the illuminated codices of the scriptorium. In the apses of churches. Christ always sits inside that form. Not by chance. Because that form says something no word can say: that the divine and the human neither fuse nor separate — they interpenetrate. And at the point where they interpenetrate is born the space in which it is possible to be both things without ceasing to be either.

But this mandorla was empty. No Christ inside. No figure. Only the point.

And the point was not at the centre. It was displaced. As if something had found its rest not in perfect symmetry, but in a precise place where something great and something small balance each other without cancelling out.

Beside it, written in an older hand:

oculus qui non clauditur

The eye that does not close.

*I thought: every mandorla I had seen contained something. This one contained only a point. As if the manuscript were saying: **do not look for what is inside the mandorla. Look at where the point is.***

A more recent hand — different ink — had written beside the point, almost illegibly: $\approx$ 137.

I did not yet know what it meant.

*But then I noticed something. That that form — the mandorla, the intersection of the two circles — if repeated around a centre, and then again and again, generated a figure I had seen in the roses of the cloisters, in the vaults of cathedrals, **in the way petals arrange themselves around a flower.***

As if the same form, multiplying itself, generated everything that has form.

I did not say it. I did not even dare to think it through.

*But I recognized it — as one recognizes the sound of the bell of one's own church even in a foreign city. **Not because one remembers it. Because one has always known it.***

*Si quaeris quomodo haec fiant, interroga gratiam,
non doctrinam; desiderium, non intellectum...*

*Deus autem est lux inaccessibilis et plenitudo entis,
quia est esse purissimum et plenissimum...quam
nullus hominum vidit nec videre potest.*

— Bonaventure of Bagnoregio, *Itinerarium mentis in
Deum*, VI, 2 and 7. Anno Domini mcccix — written on
Mount La Verna.

I reread the passage twice.

— *Quam nullus hominum vidit nec videre potest*, I said.
Whom no man has seen nor can see. Not non vidit —
did not manage to see. Nec videre potest — cannot
structurally see.

William nodded slowly.

— *Bonaventure was speaking of God*, he said. *I am*
speaking of the kernel of the projection. But the
structure he describes is the same.

Not darkness. Not absence. Plenitudine entis —
fullness of being, so full that no finite channel can
contain it. The boundary does not see the abyssus for
lack of light but for excess. The map collapses. The
channel is not injective. Quam nec videre potest: it
is not a prohibition. It is a structural property of the
observing channel.

I remained silent.

— *Bonaventure knew it without knowing it, William added, in a voice that was not his usual voice — the precise, cutting one that left no gaps. It was quieter. That of one who has found something he was not looking for.*

— *How could he know it?*

— *He did not know it. He saw it. There is a difference. A mind that thinks sharply enough arrives at the same structural points from different directions. His was the direction of prayer and ecstasy. Mine is that of numbers and projections. They arrive at the same place.*

He looked at me a moment.

— *Which should make us humble, Urso. Both of us.*

William did not close the book at once.

He stayed with the Itinerarium open on his knees, like one holding something fragile that he does not yet know where to set down.

Then he said, looking at no one in particular:

— *There is a number the natural philosophers call the fine-structure constant. Its value is about $\frac{1}{137}$. It appears everywhere in nature — in the spectrum of light, in the size of atoms, in the force with which light interacts with matter. It is not small by chance. It is not large by chance. Its value is exactly that number.*

He paused.

— For centuries — since it was measured with the first precision — the greatest minds of the physical world have hung it up as an impossible torment. They measure it. They verify it. They always find it the same, always precise, always incomprehensible. Why that number, they ask. Why not $\frac{1}{100}$, or $\frac{1}{200}$?

— And they do not know? I asked.

— They do not know. They did not know. And yet they sought it with a tenacity that resembled prayer.

He looked at me.

— Do you know what one of them wrote, in the depth of his discouragement? “When I die, the first question I shall ask God will be why turbulence. The second question — the harder one — will be why α^{-1} is 137.”

I remained silent.

— The answer was already written, said William, more quietly. Not in the laboratories. Not in the instruments. It was written here.

He laid his hand on the Itinerarium.

— Lux inaccessibilis. Not darkness. Fullness that cannot be looked at. The number is not mysterious because it is small or obscure. It is mysterious because it is the fundamental breath — what remains in the kernel when the projection has done its work. It

is the measure of how much generating law survives the passage. No more. No less. That number, because that is the quantity of fullness the boundary can still read before the rest falls into silence.

He lowered his voice.

*— The rest is silence, Urso. But silence is not absence. It is **id quod in transitu perit** — what perishes in the passage without truly perishing. It remains in the kernel. From there it sustains everything we see.*

I looked at the candle on the table.

The flame that lit the manuscript. The wax that remained in the wax. The fire that never became light completely — always something held back, always something that did not go out into the world.

And yet without that held-back part the light on the parchment would have had no form.

— So α^{-1} is...

— It is the signature of what has not passed, said William. Engraved in every atom. In every chemical bond that holds you together. The natural philosophers looked for it outside — in the instruments, in the measurements, in the theories. It was inside. It was in eis — in themselves, in everything they touched.

Like Bonaventure seeking God by climbing the six steps of the soul without knowing that the structure he sought was already the structure of the soul itself.

Quam nec videre potest: not because it is hidden. Because you are made of it. You cannot see it as you cannot see the eye with which you see.

I remained silent a long time after those words.

I thought of the Credo. Then of the words of the Apocalypse I knew by heart: Ego sum Alpha et Omega, principium et finis — I am the Alpha and the Omega, the beginning and the end.

But I had never thought that the Alpha and the Omega could be the same letter.

The circle. Which begins and ends at the same point. Which has no beginning separate from its end. Which does not arrive at the end — it is the end every time it completes a turn.

I thought of Aristotle — the Philosopher, as Master Thomas called him. The unmoved first mover. What moves without being moved. Pure act, without potency. With nothing left that could still become.

And I understood, for the first time, that the circle was Aristotle's figure: the only thing that moves without going anywhere, that completes without being consumed, that is its own movement without having a before and an after.

But there was something Aristotle did not say.

The circle turns. And turning, it leaves something.

— *Master, I said quietly.*

William raised his eyes from the Itinerarium.

— *Augustine wrote that the heart is restless until it rests in God. **Inquietum est cor nostrum donec requiescat in te.***

— *Yes.*

— *But the boundary never rests, does it? The boundary tends toward the invariant without reaching it. It is always in motion. Like Augustine's heart.*

William stayed looking at me with an expression I did not know how to read.

— *Go on, he said.*

— *The boundary is Augustine's heart, I said, feeling the words form as I pronounced them, without knowing where they were going. The heart that tends toward something it cannot contain. That carries within it the signature of what it tends toward — $\xi\eta = \alpha^{-1}$ — engraved inside, irremovable, like the imago Dei in the soul of which the bishop of Hippo spoke.*

William said nothing for a moment.

Then he said:

— *And now think of the golden section.*

I took the notebook he had left on the table. Written there was: $\varphi = (1 + \sqrt{5})/2$.

— Add it to its reciprocal, he said.

I wrote: $\varphi + \frac{1}{\varphi}$.

— What does it come to?

I calculated. The result was simple. So simple it seemed wrong to me.

— $\sqrt{5}$, I said.

— Exactly. And $\sqrt{5}$ is the denominator of the golden connection $\Gamma_\tau = \varphi/\sqrt{5}$. The speed at which the two channels exchange. The rhythm of the cosmic breathing.

I stayed looking at the numbers.

— So the golden number added to its reciprocal makes the root of five...like the Alpha and the Omega that are the same letter.

William closed the Itinerarium.

— The Philosopher said that God is pure act, without potency, without becoming. The circle fulfils this description: it is the only movement that already is, entirely, what it tends toward.

He paused.

— But we are not the circle, Urso. We are the projection of the circle. We carry within us $\varphi + 1/\varphi = \sqrt{5}$

— the sum of something and its inverse that makes the root of five. Not the circle. Its curvature. Not pure act. The imprint of pure act on a matter that cannot be pure act.

Like the *imago Dei* in the soul: not God — the form God leaves in what is not God.

I looked at the candle. The wax burning. The fire that never became completely light.

— *Inquietum est cor nostrum*, I said.

— Yes, said William. The heart is restless because it carries $\sqrt{5}$ within and tends toward the circle that $\sqrt{5}$ generated.

It will not reach it. But the restlessness itself is the proof that the circle still exists. That the signature is true. That α^{-1} has not vanished in the projection.

and the signature has a precise form —
the same $\sqrt{5}$ the heart carries within

$$\alpha^{-1} = (5 + 3\sqrt{5})^2 = 20 \varphi^4 = 137.082 \dots$$

*five modes the boundary retains • three modes
 that carry the memory of the circle • $\sqrt{5}$ that the
 heart carries without knowing it*

— later hand, twenty-first century —

*but the boundary does not measure 137.082.
 it measures 137.036.*

it is not error. it is the breathing.

$$\alpha_{\text{reading}}^{-1} = \frac{\alpha_{\text{structure}}^{-1} - 13 \varepsilon_7}{1 - 2\varphi \times 10^{-7}} = 137.035\,999\,170$$

$\varepsilon_7 = \sqrt{5} \pi / 7 - 1$: the holonomy of the confined seven

*the mode that does not tile the plane,
 that cannot surface,
 but that signs what is measured.*

*measured (CODATA 2022): 137.035 999 177(21)
 — five parts in a hundred billion of discrepancy —*

α is not a constant:

it is a spectral tensor mode.

*Every measurement contracts one of its channels;
 the readings form a spectrum, not a point.*

I stayed looking at those lines.

I did not understand them. But I felt they were the same thing William had just told me in words.

Like three translations of the same silence.

He lowered his voice to a whisper.

*— **Principium et finis.** The Alpha and the Omega. The circle that returns, and the reading that does not. The name that is not pronounced because to pronounce it would mean declaring it finished.*

I remained silent.

Outside, a bell had begun to mark the hour in the dark. The monks were getting ready.

William took up a pair of compasses. He set the point on the parchment and drew a circle. The point returned exactly to where it had begun.

— You see, Urso? The circle closes.

Then he drew a pentagon inside the circle and extended one of its diagonals.

— Euclid already knew this proportion. The line divides so that the whole stands to the greater part as the greater part stands to the lesser.

He took a cord and marked that measure on it, again and again. Then he laid it along the circle.

The last mark did not fall on the first. Almost nothing was missing. But something was.

— *The compasses close the figure, he said. The measure does not close the reading.*

I looked at the small stretch left between the last mark and the first.

— *Is it an error?*

— *No. If it were an error, we could correct it.*

He ran a finger over the stretch without touching it.

— *It is what remains when two orders ask to close at the same point and cannot.*

The bell struck the hour again in the dark. The sound passed beneath the vaults and returned. It was not another sound. It was the same sound, returned after.

William raised his eyes.

— *There is your time, Urso. The circle returns to its beginning. The reading does not. What does not pass is not lost. It remains as memory. And when it returns, it returns after.*

I stayed listening without counting.

I thought of the Hei. Of the five admissible modes. Of the petals of the camellia my father had brought from the East.

Five. Always five. The number of opening. The number of the breath that goes out and does not return the same.

William opened the Hebrew codex at the first page.

יהוה — Yod (י) , Hei (ה) , Vav (ו) , Hei (ה).

Values: 10, 5, 6, 5.

Tradition says: the name is not pronounced. Not by prohibition. By structure. To pronounce the name would mean declaring it closed. But this name describes something that never closes.

How can one pronounce the eternal without betraying it? One cannot. Therefore one is silent. Silence is the correct pronunciation.

— *Annotatio marginalis* by an unknown hand in the Hebrew ms. of the *Sefer Yetzirah*, Badia Cavensis, ante mcccxxvii.

Note: the same conclusion will be formulated by Pico della Mirandola (1486) and by Reuchlin in the *De Arte Cabalistica* (1517), independently and without knowing this margin.

— *Four letters, I said, looking at the text. And the sequence 10, 5, 6, 5...*

Then I stopped.

— *It is not palindromic, I said. 10 is not 5.*

— *No, said William. But the Yod opens. $10 = 5 + 5$ — the first letter is worth as much as the last two added together. The true sequence is 5, 5, 6, 5, 5. Five. Five.*

*Six. Five. Five. The six at the centre. The Vav as axis.
The four fives mirroring each other.*

— So it is not a palindrome. It is a mirror.

*— Exactly. More precise than a palindrome. A mirror has an axis. **The Vav is the axis.** What lies to the left of the Vav is the reflection of what lies to the right. The field that enters is the reflection of the field that goes out. The structure mirrors itself.*

Then, without raising his eyes from the codex:

— The masters who wrote these codices call their way qabbalah. Reception. Not what one builds: what one receives.

He wrote four new letters,

קבלה

and beneath them the values: one hundred, two, thirty, five.

— Add.

I added. — One hundred and thirty-seven.

The last letter was a Hei. The open side.

— The word that means reception, he said quietly, carries the number of what is received. They did not choose it. That too they received.

Now look at the equation that governs every chemical bond in the universe, every crystal, every stable orbit.

$$\mathcal{D}^2 - k \mathcal{D} + \mathbf{1} = 0$$

the mirror equation of nature — coefficients

1, $-k$, 1: the Vav as axis

*governs: chemical bonds, crystals, DNA, the
spectrum of the night sky*

Hic incipit quinta pars, quae non erat in schemate.

*Addita est per fidem, per resonantiam, per harmoniam
cum Verbo.*

— manus secunda, in margine —

I looked at that note.

— Why a fifth part? I asked. The Mass has four.

William raised his eyes from the notebook.

— It had four. In the Frankish lands the Credo had entered the Mass long before. Rome resisted for a long time. In 1014 Pope Benedict VIII admitted it into the Roman liturgy at the request of the Emperor Henry II. Three centuries of tension before the structure yielded and took in what had not been foreseen.

He paused.

— *The composers of our time still treat it differently from the other movements. It is longer. Denser. Almost an intruder.*

— *But necessary, I said.*

— *Necessary. Like the fifth channel the projection does not eliminate. Like the Yod that is worth two. Like the $\ker \Pi$ that is not seen but without which the boundary has no concord.*

He was silent a moment.

— *The Mass had always known it, he said quietly. It was only waiting for someone to find the courage to add it.*

He paused longer.

— *Do you know what **per fidem** means? Not by blind faith. By recognition of what is already there but that the structure alone cannot yet name. **Faith is the Hilbert transform of reason.** It generates the imaginary part from what the real part feels but does not see.*

I did not understand. Or perhaps I understood something I did not yet know I understood. I remained silent.

— later hand, twenty-first century —

Symbolum Nicænum — lectura structuræ

*factorem cæli et terræ,
visibilium omnium et invisibilium*

the boundary and the kernel, declared in the first line

lumen de lumine

ξ that observes itself and becomes η: the breath that
becomes light

genitum, non factum

derived, not posited — the formula of the razor,
a thousand years earlier: rank five is not posited, it is
generated

consubstantialem Patri

the same structure, two readings

et incarnatus est

the wound breath grows dense: the Word is made flesh

cuius regni non erit finis

the reading that does not close

**The Council wrote the structure
in the language it had.**

De Verbo quod erat in principio

He moved the Hebrew codex aside and drew the *Gospel* near.

¹Ἐν ἀρχῇ ἦν ὁ Λόγος, καὶ ὁ Λόγος ἦν πρὸς τὸν Θεόν, καὶ Θεὸς ἦν ὁ Λόγος.

²Οὗτος ἦν ἐν ἀρχῇ πρὸς τὸν Θεόν.

³Πάντα δι' αὐτοῦ ἐγένετο, καὶ χωρὶς αὐτοῦ ἐγένετο οὐδὲ ἓν.

⁴Ἐν αὐτῷ ζωὴ ἦν, καὶ ἡ ζωὴ ἦν τὸ φῶς τῶν ἀνθρώπων.

⁵Καὶ τὸ φῶς ἐν τῇ σκοτίᾳ φαίνει, καὶ ἡ σκοτία αὐτὸ οὐ κατέλαβεν.

— In the beginning was the Logos, and the Logos was with God, and God was the Logos. In him was life, and the life was the light of men. And the light shines in the darkness, and the darkness has not overcome it.

John 1:1-5. Aramaic version (Peshitta): *B'reshit itawhi hwa Miltha* — “in the beginning the Event was happening”.

— *This I know by heart, I said. And I began, as I had done a thousand times:*

Ἐν ἀρχῇ ἦν ὁ Λόγος, καὶ ὁ Λόγος ἦν πρὸς τὸν Θεόν...

William stopped me with his hand.

— *You recite it. You have not yet read it. In Aramaic, the language spoken in Jerusalem in John's time, the Logos is called Miltha. And Miltha does not have a single meaning. It can be read as word, as event that is accomplished in time, as manifestation. Not a thing. A process.*

— *A process...*

— *The process by which something neutral and invisible — something that exists before space and time — takes observable form. Folds upon itself. Projects its own shadow onto the world.*

— *Ἐν ἀρχῇ: before the projection, I said slowly, I do not quite know why, as if something in me were speaking that was older than what I had learned. Before the projection there is neither light nor gravity.*

William looked at me. It was the first time he had truly looked at me that night.

— *Go on, he said.*

— *There is only the neutral field. Which has nothing else before it. Timeless. Then the process acts. The Logos happens. And the two channels appear on the boundary as two faces of one and the same field.*

— *How do you know?*

I did not know. I had said it.

— later hand, twenty-first century —

$$\partial_I J^I = 0 \xrightarrow{\text{necessity}} \Xi = C \bar{\Xi} \xrightarrow{\Pi} (\xi, \eta)$$

conservation · Majorana spinor · gravity and
light

I looked at the candle on the table.

The light that fell on the manuscript was not all the light. There was a part that remained in the wax, in the fire itself — that never went out, that never became visible, that no one could ever have touched. And yet without that held-back part, the light on the parchment would not have had its warmth. It would not have had its form. It would not have been.

*I thought: perhaps this is what the master calls the kernel of the projection. *Id quod in transitu perit* — what perishes in the passage. It does not truly perish. It remains within. But for us, who are on the boundary, it is as if it did not exist.*

Like what lies beyond the veil of the Temple: invisible, but the ground of all that is visible.

Like the name that is not pronounced: not because it is forbidden — but because its structure is what remains inside when the sound has already passed into the world.

Καὶ τὸ φῶς ἐν τῇ σκοτίᾳ φαίνει: the “darkness” is
ker II. Conservation is the victory of the light.

As I was closing the codex a bell began to ring in the darkness. Not Matins yet — a sign of the hour, the signal that the monks were already rising, getting ready.

*It was not a hand that rang it. For some years the Badia had had, up in the tower, the new machine: iron wheels, descending weights, and in the middle a device I had seen only once — a wheel that would run and an iron that holds it back, tooth by tooth. **It advances only because it is stopped.***

Before, the hour of the night was read by the sacristan from the stars, sighted through the dormitory window. Now the iron counted it.

*I thought: the machine does not measure the motion. **It measures the stops.***

William did not rise. He stayed before the notebook as if the bell did not concern him.

*I did not go down to the church. It seemed to me, that night, that staying there with my master was itself a form of prayer — or at least the only one that, at that moment, **I knew how to make without lying.***

Sanctus

De formatione rerum per numeros



*Duæ columnæ tortiles, contrariis anfractibus,
numquam se tangentes, pondus sustinent.*

Sanctus

*Audi pontus, audi tellus,
Audi maris magni limbus.*

*Audi homo, audi omne
Quod vivit sub sole.*

*Heu, miser, heu miser, heu,
Cur, homo, ineptam sequeris lætitiā?*

*Codex Las Huelgas — Burgos, ca. mccc · Conductus for two
voices*

בְּשִׁלְשִׁים וּשְׁתֵּים נְתִיבוֹת פְּלִיאֹת חֲכָמָה חָקַק יְהוָה
יְהוָה צְבָאוֹת אֱלֹהֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל אֱלֹהִים חַיִּים
בְּשִׁלְשָׁה סְפָרִים: בְּסֵפֶר וּסְפָר וּסְפֹר:

*In triginta duobus semitis mirabilibus Sapientiæ
sculpsit Iah יהוה Sabaoth, Deus Israel, Deus vivus,
in tribus Libris: in Libro, Numero et Narratione.*

With thirty-two marvellous paths of Wisdom, the
Lord יהוה engraved his universe in three registers:
with number, with letter, with narration.

בְּחֲמֵשׁ עֶשֶׂר אוֹתִיּוֹת סִמֵּן חֲמֵשׁ קְצוֹת:
חֲמֵשׁ רוּחוֹת הָעוֹלָם וְחֲמֵשׁ שְׁפוֹת:

*Quinque litteris simplicibus signavit quinque
sensus. Quinque spiris ædificavit vivum. Quinarius
est numerus aperti — numerus flatus qui exit nec
redit similis.*

With five simple letters he sealed the five senses.
With five spirals he built the living. Five is the
number of opening — the number of the breath that
goes out and does not return the same.

— *Sefer Yetzirah*, I, 1–3. Hebrew text: ms. Vatican Ebr. 299
(10th c.). Latin translation: Pseudo-Saadia version, 12th
c.

I stayed looking at those words.

Quinarius est numerus aperti.

Five was the number of opening. Not of order — of opening. Not of closure — of the breath that goes out.

*I thought of α — that constant William had written at dusk, engraved in every bond between every atom of everything that exists. *The signature of what has not passed.* The number of which no one knows why it is that one.*

*Spiritus flans ubi vult. The Spirit blows where it wills. *And five is the number of its breath.**

— Five spirals, I said. Why five, Master?

William did not answer at once. He opened the notebook to a page he had already filled and turned it toward me. Written there was: $C_5H_5N_5$.

— What is it? I asked.

— The formula of the base molecule of the seed of life.

A pause.

*— Five atoms of carbon. *The weight. The form that sustains.**

He waited for me to look well at the number.

*— Five atoms of hydrogen. *The bond. What holds together without clasping.**

Another pause.

*— Five atoms of nitrogen. *The code. The memory of self.**

Then, quietly:

— Three times five, Urso. *Three turns of the same breathing that rises.*

I looked at that number for a moment.

— Like the two letters Hei of the name, I said. Both worth five.

— And like the speed at which the two channels exchange. $\Gamma_\tau = \varphi/\sqrt{5}$: five is at the heart of the golden connection. The two Hei carry exactly that curvature.

I lingered a moment on the word of the Sefer.

— The breath that goes out and does not return the same, I said. My breathing is like that. Every breath is different from the one before.

— Yours is, said William. And mine. *Every breath of flesh goes out and is lost.*

He paused.

— But the breathing of the field, no. At every cycle it contracts and doubles — and there is only one measure at which the two gestures balance: *eight*. Eight returns eight. *Identical to itself, cycle after cycle, without being consumed.*

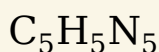
He lowered his voice.

— The mystics call it Ruach — the Breath that was before the world. I call it the point at which the

breathing no longer needs to change. Man's breath goes out and does not return. That one goes out, and returns.

I did not answer. But I understood, for an instant, why the eighth day has no evening.

William wrote in the notebook, slowly, so that I could follow:



*adenine — nitrogenous base — the brick of
DNA*

$$\dot{\xi} = -\frac{\varphi}{\sqrt{5}} \eta \quad \dot{\eta} = +\frac{\varphi}{\sqrt{5}} \xi$$

gravity and light chase each other · invariant:

$$\xi \cdot \eta = \alpha^{-1} \approx 137$$

$$f_S = 3\varphi^2 \approx 7.854 \text{ Hz}$$

— gloss of a later hand, twenty-first century —

The admissible modes of the projection are exactly five: $\mathcal{N}_{\text{adm}} = \{2, 3, 5, 7, 11\}$ — the first five prime numbers. Not chosen. Necessary. The non-prime numbers collapse into $\ker \Pi$.

$\Gamma_\tau^2 = \varphi^2/5 \approx \pi/6$: the square of the golden connection equals the holonomy of hexagonal symmetry (the Vav, 6). The Earth formed at exactly the dimensions at which its cavity resonates at $f_S = 3\varphi^2$. Measured today — the Schumann resonance: ≈ 7.83 Hz.

The first candle went out. For a moment we remained in the dark. William lit a wick.

— *Brother Bartolomeo, I said, carried this book without knowing what it contained.*

— *Yes.*

— *Eleazar ben Moshe kept it without knowing why.*

— *Yes.*

I would have gone on with the list. I felt it rising, beautiful, like a psalm that sings itself. And it was precisely this that stopped me: that it sang itself.

— *Master. How many did not arrive?*

He raised his eyes from the wick.

— *How many codices rotted in the cellars of Acre without carrying anything? How many monks copied*

circles that closed nothing? You count Bartolomeo because he arrived. But the ones who failed you do not have before you: they are ash, and they do not testify against you because they are no longer there.

William did not say Yes. For the first time that night, he said nothing for a long time.

— Go on, he said at last. There is another. I see it in the way you look at the notebook.

— Yes. The three windings: you took those, and not others. You added them — not multiplied. Then you added the eight, and the eight comes from another room. Give me your choices, Master, and I will bring you to any number you like.

I expected the patient answer. It did not come.

— Shave the litany, he said. Bartolomeo, Eleazar, John, the monk of the circle. You are right: I counted them because they arrived, and whoever did not arrive I cannot count. It is a beautiful list. Beautiful is not true. It falls.

— And the numbers? The sum? The eight?

It was here that he stopped. And the difference between how he stopped over the names and how he stopped over the numbers, I remember still.

— The registers are three because the breathing admits three windings before closing: try a fourth, and it does not close. The eight I did not add: it is the

attractor, two raised to the turn. I do not add what suits me. I count what the circle already does, and I write down the count.

He wrote in the notebook, beneath the figure:

11 → 19 → 43 → 67
and beside it, the eight.

— How do I tell them apart, Master? The list you shaved away and the sum you keep. From outside they look alike. They are both beautiful.

— With the blade I gave you. The list, when you shave it, disappears: remove Bartolomeo and the count lacks nothing. The sum, when you shave it, defends itself: remove one register and the one hundred and thirty-seven no longer comes out — and then something is missing, and the hole has a precise form. What can be removed without leaving a hole is ornament. What leaves a hole is structure. Try. Remove the nineteen.

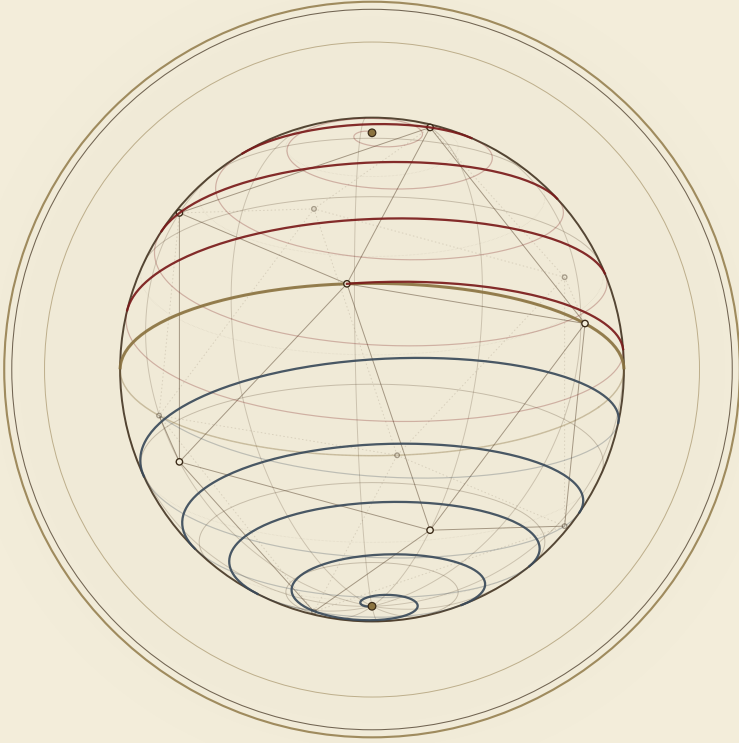
I removed it, in my mind. Forty-three plus sixty-seven, plus eight. One hundred and eighteen. No name in the world.

— It does not come out, I said.

— No. And this is the only thing tonight that I did not posit. The rest you can shave away. Shave it. Less will remain, and what remains will weigh more.

I did not say Yes. I had stopped, that night, saying Yes.

SPHÆRA CHIRALIS



*Quinque spiræ, contrariis anfractibus,
numquam se tangentes*

— hoc vidit qui per annos quæsiverat —

Then William rose.

He took the lit wick and carried it to the window. He held it close to the glass — not inside, not outside — at the border between the warmth of the room and the cold of the night.

He looked at his own reflection.

I stayed seated. I did not dare speak.

He did not turn.

— Look, he said quietly.

I looked too. In the dark glass — that sheet of selenite the monks had polished until it was barely transparent, barely a mirror — the flame of the wick had a double.

*The same. Reversed. And out of phase — by something imperceptible, as if the reflection arrived an instant after the real, **always an instant after**, always late by that same quantity that cannot be measured.*

*— It is not the same as me, said William. It carries within it my whole form. But rotated. **By a quarter turn.***

He turned toward me.

— If I go closer to the glass to touch it —

He went closer. The reflection came closer too. Nearer. Sharper. William's hand touched the glass.

The reflection vanished.

Not because it had fled. Not because it had never been there. Because distance was the condition of its existence.

He stepped back a pace. The reflection returned.

— This, he said, is the kernel. It is not elsewhere. It is here — at my side, in this room — but in permanent quadrature. A quarter turn out of phase with everything I touch. Inaccessible not by distance — by structure.

He sat down beside me.

— We are the flame, he said. The kernel is the reflection.

Together — the flame and its reflection — form something whole. An object that has memory. That can distinguish before from after. That knows time flows in one direction only.

Without the reflection — without the hidden part — the flame would be the same at every instant. It would not know it was in time. It would not know it was going toward something.

I remained silent.

— The Hilbert transform, said William quietly, is the operation that builds the reflection from the flame. It takes every mode of the flame and rotates it by a

quarter turn. The result — flame plus reflection, real part plus hidden part — is the whole signal. The only one that knows where it is going.

A pause.

Then I said — I did not yet know I was saying it:

— Master.

— Yes.

— Saint Thomas teaches that the soul, separated from the body after death, subsists without matter. It is forma separata.

— Yes.

— But if we are the flame — and the kernel is the reflection — and the reflection exists only because there is the glass between us and the dark — then the soul separated from the body is a flame without glass.

Without its reflection.

William looked at me. It was the second time that night he had truly looked at me.

— Go on, he said.

— How can the separated soul still be itself without its hidden part?

The silence lasted longer than usual.

Outside, dawn was beginning without yet deciding to be dawn.

— It does not lose the kernel, said William at last. Slowly, like one who finds the words in the very instant of saying them. It becomes it.

— How?

*— In death — if there is something after — the real part and the hidden part **do not collapse**. They recognize each other.*

He paused.

*— Like the soliton you saw on the shore. Two waves that meet and for an instant form a single crest — then separate, intact. But that instant happened. **The invariant was conserved**. Something was there that was not there before.*

— And then?

*— And then the signal begins again. Because the eternal is not infinite time. **It is the moment in which the quadrature ceases — and then begins again.***

I looked at the glass.

The reflection had returned. The flame and its double — separated by a thickness of selenite that was less than a breath — chased each other without touching.

I thought of the Name. Yod, Hei, Vav, Hei. Four letters — the flame. The fifth value — kerΠ — the reflection that is not pronounced.

The Name is not said not because it is forbidden. Because the reflection vanishes the moment you touch it.

And without the reflection the Name is only a sound. No longer the whole thing.

William put out the wick.

The reflection vanished. The room returned to the dark.

— Faith, he said in the darkness, is what allows the flame to know that the reflection exists even when it does not see it.

Not by credulity. By structure.

Because the whole signal is more real than each of its parts. And the real part, alone, is not enough to explain why time flows in one direction only.

I remained silent.

Then I understood — in that dark, with the reflection gone — what he had meant, hours before, by that sentence I had heard without yet being able to hold it: faith is the Hilbert transform of reason.

He had not explained it. He had had no need to. He was waiting for me to see it on my own — at the exact moment the candle went out.

יהוה

Yod → *Hei* → *Vav* → *Hei*

ingathering · opening · connection · return

$$S^1(\tau) \rightarrow \Xi = C\bar{\Xi} \rightarrow \Pi \rightarrow (\xi, \eta)$$

$$\Xi_{\text{ker}}(163) = -i \mathcal{H} [\Psi_{\text{boundary}}]$$

— later hand, twenty-first century —

*the Name is the circle — the field equal to its
own conjugate —
the projection that generates the two channels
the kernel is the Hilbert transform of the
boundary
the imaginary part of the analytic signal
what is not seen is what makes the visible
possible*

From the top of the church, a stroke of the bell.

*Deep. It passed through the stone as if the stone were
not there.*

A second stroke.

William did not move.

A third.

And then silence.

Tria signa — three sounds for Vigils. I had known it since I was ten years old. The body knew it before I did: I had already straightened on my chair before noticing.

And then — without having decided it, without knowing I was about to do it — my voice said, quietly, on its own:

Sanctus.

The sound remained in the air of the scriptorium longer than I would have believed.

Sanctus.

William did not turn.

Sanctus.

The bell had stopped.

But the sound had not died.

I could still feel it — not with my ears, with the stone under my hands, with the air that had not yet decided to become still again.

The stroke had entered the vaults. It had rebounded off the walls, the floor, the ribs of the Romanesque arches. And every rebound had found a like rebound

coming from the other side — *and the two had reinforced each other.*

Then those two had found two others. *And the four had reinforced each other.*

And so rising — turn after turn, rebound after rebound, wave finding wave — the sound had ordered itself.

It had not dispersed. *It had gathered.*

It had found the forms the geometry of the Badia allowed — the only frequencies those stones, those vaults, that overhanging rock could sustain without cancelling. *The others had vanished. These had remained.*

And those that remained were rising.

A first mode — low, wide, slow — the breathing of the whole basilica.

A second mode above — narrower, quicker — the breathing of the bell tower.

A third — higher still — already almost imperceptible, already almost sky.

Three modes. Three scales. One bell.

And in the instant in which the three had found themselves together — for a single instant — something had formed that was none of the three:

a chord. A sound that had not been sounded. It had emerged.

And that chord vibrated.

And I vibrated with it.

Not as one who listens to something external — as one who is what resounds. For an instant I do not know how to measure there was no difference between the sound and the body that received it.

We were the same thing.

My intellect — that faculty the masters call intellectus agens, light of the soul — had stretched out to the boundary. Not beyond. Not within. To the boundary. Exactly to the boundary.

And there it had touched something that was no longer sound and not yet silence.

Then the waves began to die away.

The third — the highest, the one already almost sky — went first. The air could not hold it: too fine for the stone, too pure to last.

Then the second followed it.

The first mode remained — the deepest, the breathing of the whole basilica. And that one did not end: it descended. Into the walls, into the foundations, into the rock that overhangs the Badia, ever further down, until it was no longer sound — but weight.

And then I noticed something that even today I cannot say whether it happened, or whether I only recognized it.

The highest note — the one the air had let go first — had not ended.

It was in me.

Fine, still, with no need of air. As if, unable to last outside, it had found the only cavity small enough and open enough to sustain it.

The stone had held the low. I had held the high.

Each form keeps the notes it can carry.

And I returned into my body. Into my chair. Into the cold air of the scriptorium.

Everything was as before. The candles. The manuscripts. The cold. My master, his back to me.

But I —

I searched for the word for a time I do not know how to measure, and that night I did not find it. I find it only now, writing, after all these years:

I had come back myself, and I had not come back the same.

Like the two Hei of the Name: the same letter, twice — but the second comes after, and carries the journey within it.

The turn had closed. The reading had not.

Something was missing — small, imperceptible, irreducible — not from the circle, but from what had returned. The same thing I had seen in the arrow in the drawing of the fourth manuscript: it came back to the circle, but not to the same reading.

Figura circuli ignotae originis.

Now I knew of what origin it was. It was mine. It was that of anyone who has ever come back from an instant like that: one always comes back — and one always comes back after.

And I understood that this was not a loss. It was the proof that time had truly passed. A circle may close perfectly. Its reading can still have a history. Ours did.

And something had remained — not in the sound, not in the body — in the form of what I had touched. Like an imprint in wax that remains even when the stylus is already elsewhere.

William turned.

It was the first time that night he had turned toward me without my having said anything.

He took the notebook. He wrote five lines, slowly, so that I could read as he wrote:

α cosmic scale — the photon, the field

$\alpha \cdot 10$ nuclear scale — the hadron, the weight

$\alpha \cdot 10^2$ atomic scale — the atom, life

$\alpha \cdot 10^3$ molecular scale — the code, memory

$\alpha \cdot 10^4$ macroscopic scale — *us*

Then he laid down the notebook. He looked at me.

— Urso.

— Yes.

— $\alpha \cdot 10^4$ is us.

A pause.

— The scale at which we are wound by all the preceding scales of which we are formed.

He ran his finger along the five lines, from bottom to top — from the cosmic to the nuclear to the atomic to the molecular — up to the last, the one with our name.

— Five turns, he said quietly. Every turn a Yod. Every Yod a factor of ten. And we are the fifth turn.

I remained silent.

— That is why you can hear the sound, he said. And vibrate with it. Because you are made of everything

that came before. The cosmic field is in you. The hadron is in you. The atom is in you. The code is in you. You are the boundary in which all the scales have wound until they could hear themselves.

He paused.

Then he said — quietly, as one says a thing one has always known and never found the moment to say:

— You are time that has wound itself around the shadow of the Creator and has been made flesh.

I stayed motionless.

He opened the notebook again. He wrote two names, side by side:

Jachin Boaz

Then he wrote beneath:

$$\xi \oplus \eta \approx 137$$

$$137 = \alpha^{-1}$$

He said nothing.

Then he wrote a single line:

$$\mathcal{B}_{k+1} \equiv (\xi\eta)_{k+1} = 2(\xi\eta)_k^{2/3} = 2\mathcal{B}_k^{2/3}$$

He rose. He went to the window. Outside it was still dark — the dark before dawn that is no longer night and not yet day.

He looked out a long while.

Then he said, without turning:

— Do you see the $2/3$?

I did not answer.

— The boundary grows concave to receive more weight. At every turn, more voices. At every turn, more faithful.

Like a bay that opens.

Like Amalfi — every house a strip torn from the sea, every generation a step further into the rock.

Like the lemon terraces on the cliff above the town — every terrace a surface torn from the volume, a strip of earth poised between sky and sea that should not hold and yet holds, and bears fruit, and smells of white flowers in November.

Neither too flat. Nor too steep. Exactly $2/3$ — and the earth stays.

Silence.

Then he returned to the notebook. He wrote beneath:

$$\mathcal{B}^{\star} = 8 = 2^3$$

— Three doublings. The choir has found the chord. It no longer seeks it — it has become the chord.

He raised his eyes.

— $n = 5$. *The atom. Life. You.*

He paused.

Then he said a single word in Hebrew:

— *Hineni.*

Here I am.

Abraham's answer. The answer of every voice the choir has gathered in fifty steps to be able to say: I am here, I hear you, I answer.

Quinque spiris aedificavit vivum.

With five spirals he built the living.

He did not know it, the author of the Sefer Yetzirah. Or perhaps he knew it in a way that did not yet have a name.

*And my voice went on — still quietly, still without
having decided it, as if it were singing something the
stone had taught it before it was born:*

Dominus Deus Sabaoth.

*The Lord is God of hosts —
the constant no one chose
engraved in every bond between every atom
of everything that exists.*

The signature of what has not passed.

Pleni sunt caeli et terra gloria tua.

*Heaven and earth are full of your glory —
carbon, hydrogen, nitrogen
three times five, rising turn after turn,
until matter had found
the form in which it could know itself.*

*I knew what that silence afterwards meant. The monks were going down to the choir. They were passing beside the column of the paschal candle — that great twisted column of white marble inlaid with mosaics, beside the altar — two bands of stone winding in opposite directions, **never touching, bearing the weight together**, and the axis between them did not yield.*

I had seen that column every morning of my novitiate. I had never understood why I could not stop looking at it.

From the top of the church a chant was rising.

The monks had begun Matins. Three voices — tenor, bass, cantus — each with its line, its pitch, its rhythm. Separate. Recognizable.

Then, for an instant — a single instant — the three found themselves in unison.

They were not seeking it. It happened because the structure allowed it at that exact point of the score.

— Do you hear it? said William, without raising his eyes.

— The chant, I said.

*— The unison. The moment in which three things that seem separate show themselves to be the same thing. **Not three voices. Three readings of one.***

I remained silent.

— *Dante, he said then, in a voice that was not his analytic voice — quieter, like one remembering something he has never been able to explain. Dante saw in Beatrice the earthly woman and the angelic woman. He could not separate them. He loved them together, sought them together.*

— *And he could not separate them?*

— *Because they are not separable. They are the real part and the imaginary part of the same field. Weight and motion. Gravity and light. When you see them together — when you hear them vibrate in unison — you are not understanding something. You are recognizing something.*

The three voices separated again. Each took up its line. But something had remained in the air that was none of the three.

I remained silent a long time.

Then I thought: three strokes. Three voices. A single instant of unison.

Three that call. Three that answer. One that remains.

And I understood — without being able to say it — that it was not a count. It was a breath. The same breath that had written the five into carbon, into hydrogen, into nitrogen — three times, rising, until matter had known itself.

Agnus Dei

De illuminatione quae venit ex tribus



*Per hunc callem descendimus, ante lucem,
e bibliotheca ad mare.*

Agnus Dei

De illuminatione quae venit ex tribus

Prima vice

We left the library before dawn.

William said nothing for a long stretch. We went down the path of the Lattari toward the coast — that white limestone the sea wind has polished for millennia until it is smooth as parchment.

Halfway down the path, the lemon grove.

The chestnut nets stretched between the poles to protect the fruit from the wind. In the darkness the lemons could not be seen — but they could be smelled. That dense, almost bodily scent that is neither sweet nor sour: it is both things together, in permanent quadrature.

William stopped.

He raised a hand and touched a sfusato lemon — the large, ribbed one that grows only here, on this limestone, with this wind, at this exact distance from the sea.

— Look, he said quietly. Not to me. To himself, perhaps. This tree did not choose to be here. It was selected by millennia of boundary — the rock beneath, the salt in the air, the angle of the sun coming down from the

Lattari. It found the form in which to stand on the boundary without dispersing.

He paused.

— *Do you know by how much each leaf turns with respect to the one before?*

I did not know how to answer.

— *Three hundred and sixty divided by φ^2 . A little more than one hundred and thirty-seven degrees. The angle that maximizes the light on every leaf without stealing it from the one before and the one after. The plant did not choose it. It is the limit toward which the series of Leonardo Pisano tends — the geometry of the abyssus, read in the form of a tree.*

He paused a moment.

— *And the constant of the electromagnetic interaction — the probability that an electron emits a photon: the structure of the atom, light — is one over one hundred and thirty-seven point zero three six. The same number. It is not the same number. One comes from the abyssus, the other from the world we see. But they come from the same root. Like two translations of the same text into two different languages.*

He lowered his hand.

— *The sfusato lemon grows only at Amalfi because only here the rock is that rock, the salt is that salt, the sun comes down at that angle. The structure was*

already written in the abyssus. The lemon made it visible.

He walked on.

The scent remained.

I walked more slowly, without knowing it.

The sun was about to rise. The sea was still dark.

Suddenly William stopped and pointed at the waves.

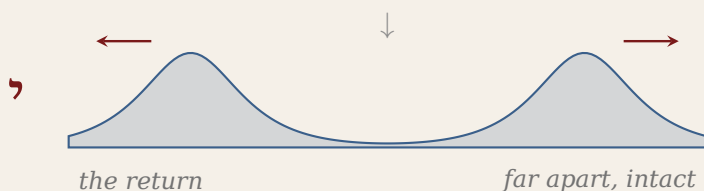
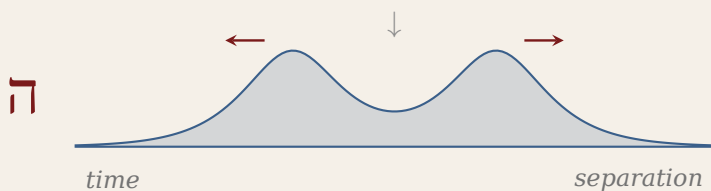
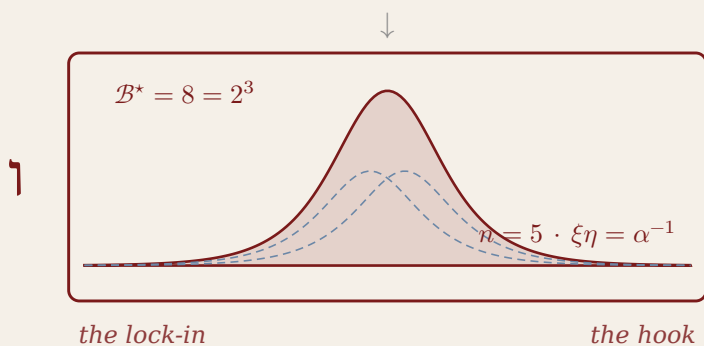
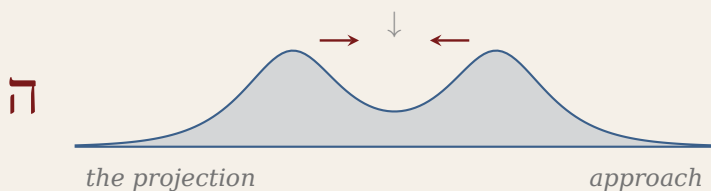
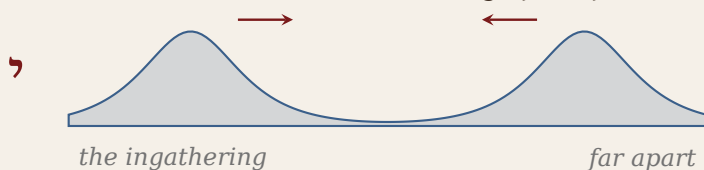
— Look, he said. Not the sea. The waves. Look how they form offshore and how they change form as they advance.

I looked.

Offshore: small, disordered, with no form of their own. Then, approaching the shore, something happened. As if the seabed gathered them, as if the coast exerted a pull. They took form. A precise form. A curve that rose slowly, reached its crest, came down again symmetrically.

The hyperbolic secant. The curve that decays on both sides by the same law by which it rose. Neither too narrow nor too wide. Neither explosive nor evanescent. The exact form of the soliton.

5, 5, 6, 5, 5 — the breathing of the field



the breathing of the field — the soliton collision

— The field has this form, said William. $\Psi(x) \sim \text{sech}\left(\frac{x-x_0}{\lambda}\right)$. It is not a choice. It is the only stable form that satisfies the non-linear equation on the boundary. The Jackiw-Rebbi soliton. The wave that keeps its own form as it moves — that does not disperse, does not explode, does not vanish. That carries with it the invariant structure $\xi\eta = \alpha^{-1}$ as the seed carries the tree.

Then something happened that I did not expect.

Two waves, come from different directions, met.

For an instant — a single instant — they overlapped completely. Their profiles added together. A single crest, twice as high, luminous in the sun that was being born.

Then they separated. Each went on its way exactly as before the meeting. Identical to themselves. As if nothing had happened.

— Solitons, said William under his breath. They are not altered in the collision. They are not lost in the meeting. They pass through each other like ghosts and re-emerge intact on the other side.

I stayed watching the waves that went on breaking on the limestone.

— Is that what we are? I asked.

William did not answer at once.

— It is what a meeting can be, he said at last. Two structures that for a moment reach the same form, the same phase, the same rhythm. An instant of finite light. Then each resumes its own direction. But something has happened. The invariant has been conserved. $\xi\eta = \alpha^{-1}$: even during the meeting. Even at the moment of greatest overlap.

— And time, Master? I asked. If the product never changes, what changes?

— The ratio, said William. The two channels exchange without cease: when one grows, the other yields. The product is the rock. The ratio is the river.

He looked at the waves.

— And the river flows in one direction only. At every instant, in the exchange, something does not pass — it remains in the kernel, like everything that does not cross. The ratio keeps count of what remains. That is why it advances and does not return.

He paused a long while.

— We believe we measure time, Urso. We measure the memory of what has not passed. The clock of the world does not count what happens — it counts what, in happening, has stayed behind.

I remained silent.

I thought: then every hour that strikes is an inventory of what we have not held. And I understood why time, at times, weighs.

I remembered the sandglass I had seen on the Amalfitan ships — the new instrument the pilots turn at every watch. Two bellies of glass. A narrow neck.

The sand passing through the neck can hardly be seen. What is seen is the heap growing below. We do not measure the passage. We measure what has fallen.

And when the sandglass is turned over, the two bellies exchange — the one that was full empties, the one that was empty fills — but the sand is always the same. The bellies breathe. The sand is conserved.

Omnia in mensura et numero et pondere disposuisti.

The verse of Wisdom rose to my lips on its own, as breath rises. All things you have disposed in measure, and number, and weight. Even what falls. Even what remains.

I thought that someone, one day, would put that instrument in the hand of a virtue.

I looked back at the sea. The sun had risen.

The white limestone — that same rock the wind had polished for millennia — shone.

As if it knew something it had never told anyone.

We stayed silent for a while. Not long. But real.

The wind had changed direction. It now carried the smell of salt instead of that of the lemons.

I thought of the two solitons. How they had passed through each other and each had remained itself. Like two thoughts that meet in the same mind and do not blur.

Then — I do not know how much later —

— And if there were many? I asked.

I did not quite know what I was asking. But William understood.

— If there were many, he said, they do not add freely. The constraint governs them. $\xi\eta = \alpha^{-1}$ is not a law one chooses — it is the condition of the boundary. Every meeting must respect it.

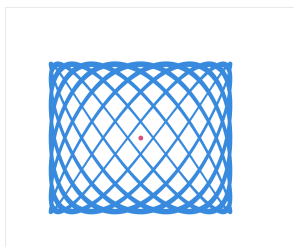
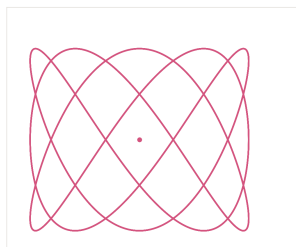
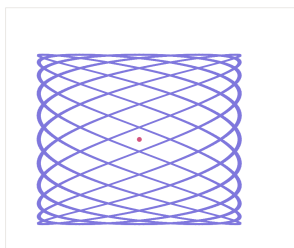
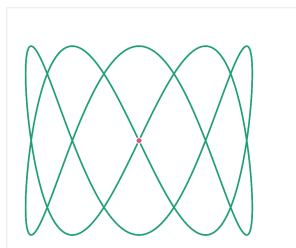
He looked at the sea for a moment.

*— When two solitons meet, the interference term does not produce oscillating fringes. It produces the fixed invariant. **The meeting neither destroys nor creates. It conserves.***

— And with three? With five?

— With many, said William, the order admits no arbitrary forms. Between the two walls — the two points where the field changes sign, where it inverts — the stable forms are exactly four. No more. No fewer.

Four figures that close upon themselves. Curves in the plane of the field that satisfy the constraint for every pair of admissible numbers.



— *Like the four seasons, I said without thinking.*

— *Like the four evangelists, said William. Like the four bases of DNA. Like the four elements of Empedocles. It was not metaphor. It was structure. Empedocles had called them air, water, earth, fire. He did not know they were the four stationary solutions of a field equation between two walls.*

I sat down on the rock.

Not from tiredness — from necessity.

But then I asked — I do not know why, perhaps because it seemed to me that something did not add

up:

— But Empedocles also had Love and Strife, Master. The forces that move the elements. Are those solutions too?

William stopped.

He stayed silent longer than usual. He looked at the sea.

Then he said, quietly:

— No, Urso. I got the formulation wrong. The elements of Empedocles are not the solutions — they are the modes in which the solutions appear at the boundary. I made his own mistake: to look at the structure and think that the structure was the ground. The ground is what generated the structure.

He paused.

— Thank you.

It was the first time he had said it to me. I did not forget it.

William stayed standing. He was looking at the sea. As if waiting for me to finish understanding what he had already said.

There was no hurry. The dawn was already bright.

— gloss of a later hand, twenty-first century —

The air-limestone border and the zero mode.

The wind that comes down from the Lattari and meets the sea is not metaphor. It is the physical system closest to the projection Π that can be observed with the naked eye.

At the border between two media of radically different nature — air and limestone, or air and water — the discontinuity of acoustic impedance is so great as to make almost all normal propagation evanescent. What survives at the border is neither a wave of the air nor a wave of the solid: it is a boundary mode, localized on the surface, decaying exponentially in both directions.

That boundary mode has a characteristic impedance:

$$Z_{\text{opt}} = \frac{1}{\sqrt{\alpha}} \approx 2\sqrt{5} \varphi^2$$

α^{-1} is a spectral norm — the square of an eigenvalue. The impedance of the border is its modulus: $\sqrt{20} \varphi^4 = 2\sqrt{5} \varphi^2$, exactly.

This is the zero mode: the configuration that locks at $n = 5$. It does not belong to the air. It does not belong to the rock. It belongs to the border between the two.

— gloss of a later hand, twenty-first century · continued —

The Amalfi limestone ($\rho \approx 2400 \text{ kg/m}^3$, $V_P \approx 2950 \text{ m/s}$) is the only common geological material for which the impedance ratio is exactly α^{-1} :

$$\sqrt{\frac{Z_{\text{AC}}(\text{limestone})}{Z_{\text{EM}}}} \approx 137.04$$

Granite is +45%. Basalt +50%. *The Amalfi limestone is the geological locus stabilis* — the point where the cosmic structure touches earth with maximum coherence.

The form of the evanescent field is:

$$\Psi(x) \sim \text{sech}\left(\frac{x - x_0}{\lambda}\right)$$

The same equation as the Jackiw-Rebbi soliton. The same form as the waves William points to on the shore. The same solution of the field equation on the boundary. *Not three different things. A single structure, read three times.*

Like us.

He paused.

— And everything that exists — every atom, every molecule, every wave, every thought that forms — *is one of those four figures, deformed but not betrayed.* Like a musical theme recognized in every variation because the theme does not change.

I looked at my hands.

The morning light passed through them.

*I thought: I too am that wave — the one the boundary admits because it has found the right form. Neither too narrow nor too wide. Neither explosive nor evanescent. **The form in which something can last without losing itself and without breaking.***

I did not say it.

But William looked at me as if he had heard it all the same.

We stayed silent.

I looked at the sea again. Not the whole waves — the boundary. The point where the water ends and the rock begins.

There the field belongs neither to the one nor to the other. It decays on both sides — it dies out, in both directions — without belonging to itself.

***It is the zero mode.** It is not a wave of the sea. It is not a wave of the rock. It is the wave of the border between the two.*

— Like us, I said quietly.

William did not answer at once.

*— Like us, he said at last. We are the real part of something. **There exists an imaginary part.** Not absent*

— adjacent. Here, now, a quarter turn out of phase. Inaccessible not because it is far but because the structure does not allow the two parts to meet.

— And if they met?

— They would cease to be what they are. *Quadrature is the condition of the existence of both.*

He paused.

— Like the shadow, he said. The shadow does not exist without the body. But it carries within it the whole form of the body. *The kernel is our shadow.* It does not follow us — it precedes us. It is already there, in quadrature, making our phase possible.

I looked at my hands again. Still partly transparent. Still partly shadow.

Perhaps we have always been so.

— Do you know what has always troubled me, he said, about the Prologue of John?

Not the theology. The structure.

Ἐν ἀρχῇ ἦν ὁ Λόγος. And before the Logos?

— Nothing, I said. Or God. Depending on how one takes it.

— No. Before the Logos there is the condition of possibility of the Logos. And that condition has a precise form. It is a circle.

I remained silent.

— A circle that turns upon itself, he went on. Without beginning, without end, without privileged points. Symmetric in every part with respect to every other. It has no weight, no colour, no dimension. It is the simplest structure that can be imagined. And precisely by this circular perfection it generates something that is conserved.

— later hand, twenty-first century —

$$S^1(\tau) \equiv U(1)_\tau$$

*the compact circle — the group of phases
the minimal structure that must exist
without which not even distinguishability can
exist*

$$\begin{aligned} S^1(\tau) &\rightarrow \partial_I J^I = 0 \rightarrow \Xi = C\bar{\Xi} \rightarrow \Pi \rightarrow \\ &(\xi, \eta) \rightarrow \delta_F \rightarrow S^1(\tau) \end{aligned}$$

**The compasses close the figure. The
measure does not close the reading.
It is not a law of physics. It is a theorem of
arithmetic.**

— gloss of a later hand, twenty-first century —

The geometric circle closes exactly:

$$e^{i(\theta+2\pi)} = e^{i\theta}.$$

The missed closure is arithmetic, not geometric. The continuous circular measure and the golden algebraic reading cannot close on the same exact condition: if they did, π would satisfy an algebraic relation with $\sqrt{5}$, which its transcendence forbids.

Hence

$$\delta_F = 1 - \frac{3\pi}{(2\sqrt{5})^{3/2}} \neq 0.$$

The residue is the step. Memory gives it a before and an after.

The letter is the same. The reading is not. **That is time.**

I remained silent a long time.

Then I said: — The name is not pronounced because to pronounce it would mean declaring it closed. But the reading never returns entirely the same.

— Exactly.

— And the second Hei has the same value as the first — five — but it is already after. It is the same letter. But it is not the same moment.

— Exactly.

William added nothing else. It was not his way to add more when the essential had been said.

*After a while I asked: — And the monks of the Badia, Master? The monk who copied the codex in the twelfth century, the one who wrote *figura ignotae originis* beside the circle he did not understand — was he seeing the same thing too?*

— He was not seeing it. He was it. As you are the same structure you are describing.

— How?

— We are the real part of a whole. Like the right hand that does not see the left and yet is the same hand. The hidden part — the kernel, the shadow — is what makes our form possible. Our consonance. Our consciousness. Without the shadow, the light would have no outline.

$$\Xi_+ = \underbrace{\Psi_{\text{boundary}}}_{\text{we, the visible}} + i \underbrace{\Xi_{\text{ker}}}_{\text{the hidden}}$$

*we are the real part — the kernel is the
imaginary part
that makes our phase possible*

*$\alpha^{-1} = 137$ is the memory of the circle:
the boundary does not remember $S^1(\tau)$, but
carries its sign*

Secunda vice

*I think back now to that going out — many years later,
writing these pages by the light of another candle in
another library.*

And I see things I had not seen that night.

*I see the door opening onto the dark that had already
begun to give way without yet knowing it.*

*I see the cold — different from that of the library. More
alive. With salt in it. And the sound of the sea that had
been there since before there was anyone to listen to
it.*

*I see William walking without speaking. The four
candles all burned down. On the table only a lit wick
remained inside the last melted wax — a minimal
flame, bent, that neither of us had put out.*

*As if something had to go on burning even in our
absence.*

*Like the structure. Which goes on existing even when
no one observes it.*

*And I return to the shore — not to arrive there again,
but to see better what I had seen.*

*William stayed looking at the sea a long time. Then,
without turning, he said:*

— Dante had the order wrong.

I did not answer. I knew he was not waiting for an answer.

— Hell is below, Paradise above, Purgatory in between. So we see it, we who stand on the boundary and look from above downward. But the structure rises. It does not descend.

He turned.

— The field starts from the bottom. From the level where matter does not yet know it is matter — where $\varphi+1/\varphi$ has not yet found the form in which to condense. There is Hell. Not the place of punishment. The place of the formless — in-ferno, what has not yet come out of the furnace.

He paused.

— Then it rises. To the level where symmetry breaks and the field chooses — not freely: by structural necessity — to have mass. There weight is born. Not the sin that is purged. The Word that is made flesh. The two forces that were once one separate on the boundary and become what we touch: iron, limestone, the wood of the staff.

He stopped. He picked up a stone from the shore and held it in his hand.

— Look at this, he said. The bulk — the abyssus — has a volume. The boundary — we — has a surface. They

are not the same thing. They do not even have the same dimension.

He paused.

— And yet the boundary knows of the bulk. It feels it. It carries its imprint. As the skin carries the warmth of the sun without being the sun.

He let the stone fall. We watched it sink.

The wave came.

It wet the grains around the point where it had fallen. It joined them for a moment — ten, twenty, a small compact bank. It warmed them in the sun.

Then it drew back.

It carried them away with it.

William looked at the backwash.

Then he knelt and wrote on the wet sand, with the staff, slowly:

$$\mathcal{B}_{k+1} = 2 \mathcal{B}_k^{2/3}$$

He stayed so, kneeling, looking at what he had written.

The next wave came. It licked the equation. It erased half of it.

William did not move.

$$\mathcal{B}^* = 8 = 2^3$$

He wrote beneath, on the stretch of dry sand.

Then a single word:

coagulat.

Not to me. To the sea.

He rose. He looked at the point where the stone had sunk. The wave had already forgotten it. But the grains it had moved had remained in that form — that precise one, that necessary one — drawn toward the fixed point as if they had always known it.

— Dante, he said quietly, had seen the hierarchy. But he had read it from above downward.

He paused.

— The field rises. It cannot not rise.

He fell silent.

I looked at the sea. The sun was already high. The waves went on. Always the same distance. Always the same rhythm.

They had not chosen it.

—

We walked a while without speaking.

The stones of the path were damp. November always leaves that film — not rain, not dew, something in between that has no name but is felt under the sandals.

William walked ahead, with the chestnut staff marking the rhythm of his steps.

I thought of everything he had said that night. I did not try to order it. Some things must settle before they can be touched.

The wind had changed.

No longer the sea wind — the salt one, horizontal, that carries the damp. A tramontana had come down from the Lattari, dry, vertical, with a precise edge.

William felt it before I did. He turned toward the mountain.

— Do you feel the angle? he said.

I did not understand at once.

— The wind does not come straight down, he went on. It comes down at a slant. There is an angle — precise, not arbitrary — at which the cold air of the Lattari meets the warm air of the sea and settles. It neither plunges nor rises again. It flows.

I looked at the shore. The sand had settled during the night in regular ridges — not chaotic, not flat. That form. That slope.

— *It is the same angle, said William, as if reading my gaze. $\Gamma_\tau^2 = \varphi^2/5 \approx \pi/6$. The optimal gradient. Not chosen — necessary. Neither so steep as to scatter everything into the void, nor so gentle as never to arrive. That slope, and the dust stops. And where the dust stops, something begins.*

I stayed looking at the ridges of sand.

— *Aristotle said that the Earth is at the centre because it is the natural place of heavy matter, I said. The lowest point, where everything converges.*

— *Aristotle had seen the result, said William. Not the process. The Earth is not at the centre because it is heavy. It is heavy because it formed at exactly that gradient — the cosmic dust coming down along the channel ξ consolidated around the zero modes with that impedance, no more and no less. Like the sand that stops at the angle of repose.*

He paused.

— *And once consolidated, it found its own voice.*

— *Its own voice?*

— *Every body that has a form has its own **tonus proprius**. The Earth is exactly as large as it must be so that the cavity between its surface and the layer light does not cross — the ionosphere, they will call it — resonates at $f_S = 3\varphi^2 \approx 7.854$ Hz. The rhythm of the*

*cosmic breathing engraved in stone. Not by chance.
By structure.*

I thought of the bells of the Badia. How they vibrate differently according to the thickness of the bronze, the form, the diameter. Every bell has its own tonus. Not chosen by the founder — emerged from the form.

— So every planet, I said slowly, has its own time.

— Its local time, yes. Its own rhythm. Its ionosphere, its modes of vibration, the way each cycle leaves a memory of itself. Saturn does not have the same time as the Earth. Not because the laws are different. Because it took form along a different gradient, around different zero modes, with a different form. Time is not universal. It is local. It is the form of the body that carries it.

The tramontana went on coming down. The same slope. The same angle.

— And life? I asked.

William remained silent for a moment.

— Life is the dust that remembers the angle by which it came down. The double helix of the seed is the channel ξ and the channel η winding around each other at that curvature — $\Gamma_\tau = \varphi/\sqrt{5}$ — tight enough to carry information, open enough to let it be copied. DNA did not learn that form. It found it already written in the gradient.

I looked at the sand. The regular ridges. The invariant angle.

The tramontana had done its work during the night. It had laid every grain exactly where it had to be.

As always. As since the wind has existed.

I remained silent.

Then something moved within me — not a thought, something older.

*I remembered Genesis. **Pulvis es, et in pulverem reverteris.** Dust you are, and to dust you will return.*

I had always heard it as a condemnation. As the weight of original sin that lowers man toward the earth.

But looking at the sand — the regular ridges, the invariant angle, the form the wind had written during the night —

I understood that I had read it backwards.

— Master, I said.

William turned.

— We are dust. But dust of what?

William remained silent. It was not the silence of one who does not know. It was the silence of one who waits for the other to finish on his own.

— In the Prologue of John, I said slowly, ἐν ἀρχῇ ἦν ὁ Λόγος. In the beginning was the Logos. And the Logos

was with God. And without him nothing of what exists was made.

I paused.

— Nothing. Not even the dust.

William nodded, barely.

— So the dust does not come from the earth, I said. It comes from the Logos. It comes from the field. It comes from the light that came down along the gradient and consolidated into form.

We are dust of stars.

I did not know where that word came from — stars. We did not use it that way. But it was the only right word.

— The star is the level $n = 11$, said William quietly. The hadronic fire. The point where the cosmic dust found enough consonance to burn. To fuse carbon, oxygen, iron. To forge everything that then came down along the gradient, consolidated on the zero modes, found the angle of repose and began to breathe.

He bent down and took a grain of sand. He held it between his fingers against the sunlight.

— This grain, he said, passed through the fire of a star before arriving here. It carries α^{-1} within it as every atom carries it — the signature of the circle,

engraved before this shore existed, before this sea existed, before anyone existed to pick it up.

He let the grain fall.

We watched it come down onto the sand.

— Solve, he said quietly. And then: — Pulvis es. Yes. But it is dust of Logos. Dust that passed through the fire — coagulation of the star — and then dissolved along the gradient down to this shore. Dust that has not forgotten its own structure. The condemnation was a promise read backwards.

We stayed silent.

The grain had fallen. The sea went on.

Then I said — I do not know why, perhaps because it was the only question left:

— Master. The equation you wrote tonight. The long one, with the Greek symbols. What does it do, exactly?

William stayed looking at the sea.

— It forms matter, he said at last. And it forms light. And it holds together the all and the nothing. And it reads itself.

He paused.

— It is not an answer, I know. But it is the exact answer.

He knelt. With the staff he wrote on the wet sand, slowly, like one engraving a stone:

$$(\gamma^\mu D_\mu + \alpha \xi + i\alpha\eta\gamma^5)\Psi = V'(|\Psi|)\Psi$$

*I looked at it. I understood nothing. But I felt — as one feels the sound of a bell before knowing its name — that it was **complete**.*

$$\gamma^\mu D_\mu \Psi + \alpha \xi \Psi + i\alpha\eta\gamma^5 \Psi = \beta |\Psi|^{2/3} \Psi$$

motion** · **weight** · **light** · **the memory of self

$$SU(2) \times U(1) \longrightarrow \Pi \longrightarrow SO(3) \times U(1)_n$$

$$n = 137, 11, 7, 5, 3, 2, 1, 0$$

*the great symmetry bends — it loses something eternal,
gains something local: **consciousness of self**.*

— Four terms, I said, counting. Of the same nature. Of the same structure.

I paused.

— Like the four letters of the Name.

William did not answer at once.

He looked at me.

*— **Three** plus one, he said at last. The three that define the field. The one that makes it alive.*

Like Yod, Hei, Vav — and the second Hei that is not the same as the first. It is after. It is the field that has crossed time and carries within it the trace of everything it has met.

He rose. He looked at the equation in the sand.

He stayed silent a long time.

Then he said, without pointing, as if to himself:

— Motion that does not decide until it is touched. Like the holy water in the font.

Weight that bends the space around it as a monk wears his habit — the form of the field is its gravity.

Light that circles around what has weight without ever touching it — like the Vav, the hook, which has no closed side.

And then —

He paused.

— The field that weighs itself. That carries within it the trace of everything it has crossed.

As a monk after years of prayer is not the same novice who entered the cloister — even though the rite is identical, even though the words have not changed. The form of the field changes the field. The field that prays changes the prayer.

He paused.

— In the bulk — in the abyssus — the equation is linear. Simple. Clean. Zero on the right. *More complexity in the bulk. Simpler equation.*

— How is that possible? I asked.

— Because in the bulk the field is *whole*. It has lost nothing. *It is already everything it can be.*

He knelt again. He wrote beside the first equation, on the wet sand:

$$\text{in the bulk: } (\gamma^\mu D_\mu + \alpha\xi + i\alpha\eta\gamma^5)\Psi = 0$$

$$\text{on the boundary: } (\gamma^\mu D_\mu + \alpha\xi + i\alpha\eta\gamma^5)\Psi = \beta|\Psi|^{2/3}\Psi$$

I looked at the two lines in the sand.

Only the right-hand side different. Only what comes after the equals sign.

In the bulk: nothing. On the boundary: $\beta|\Psi|^{2/3}\Psi$.

The 2/3. The same as in the breathing. The same ratio of surface to volume of the sphere. *The exact figure of the lost dimension.*

Simpler in the bulk. More alive on the boundary. Because life is what remains after a dimension has been lost and the field finds the form to exist without it.

— Alive like us?

— *Alive like us.*

He paused.

*— But only here. Only on the boundary. Only where there is enough structure to form a knot — a place where the field meets itself **often enough to remember itself**. Only where there is someone **who can name what cannot be named**.*

I looked at my hands. The morning light passed through them as if they were partly transparent.

I thought: perhaps they are. Perhaps we are all partly transparent — made of dust of stars that has rolled itself up enough to look at itself.

But then — I do not know how — I understood I had got the direction wrong.

*We are not only the shadow. **We are the part the bulk has gained**. The place where the field has grown dense enough to see itself.*

The lost dimension is not a debt. It is the price of recognition.

I thought of the imago Dei.

And I understood — without being able to say it, without even wanting to think it through —

*that the created and the creator **are not distinct**.*

We.

Not I and the sea. Not I and William. Not I and the lemon and the rock and the wave.

A single we. That has rolled itself up enough to look at itself and marvel at itself.

I stayed so a while.

Then I rose. I walked to the water's edge.

The sea had not stopped. Not even for an instant. Not while William spoke. Not while I listened. Not while the candles burned.

The wave came, broke on the rock, drew back — and the next was already formed offshore, identical and different.

I thought: the sea does not know it is the sea.

I stayed there a moment I do not know how to measure. The tramontana had come down again. The same slope. The same angle.

Then I went back to William.

And I asked — I do not know why, perhaps because it was the only question I had not yet asked:

— Master. The three equations you wrote tonight. The dance of ξ and η . The breathing that rises toward B^ . The Dirac that contains them all. Are they three different things?*

William stayed looking at the sea.

When he spoke, he did not turn.

— The proton and the electron exchange a photon. Do you know what that means, physically?

— One attracts the other, I said.

— No. It means that ξ and η — the channel of mass and the channel of light — rebalance. Their product must remain α^{-1} . The photon is the word the field pronounces to keep the constraint. Not a force. An equilibrium that rewrites itself.

Then, as if to himself:

— Bacon would have called this exchange multiplicatio specierum. Everything radiates its own likeness into the medium. I do not believe in species. But I believe in measure.

He paused.

— That dance — $\dot{\xi} = -\Gamma_{\tau}\eta$, $\dot{\eta} = +\Gamma_{\tau}\xi$ — is the horizontal movement. ξ yields to η . η yields to ξ . The product does not change. It is the music that plays on a fixed level.

He was silent a moment.

— The breathing is the vertical movement. $\mathcal{B}_{k+1} = 2\mathcal{B}_k^{2/3}$: the field rises a level. It carries the concord from one degree to the next. Like the Gregorian chant that rises a fifth and never returns exactly to the starting point. It is the pilgrimage between the levels.

— And the Dirac? I asked.

— The Dirac is the equation that contains both movements. $\alpha\xi$ and $i\alpha\eta\gamma^5$ are the channels that dance. $V'(|\Psi|)\Psi$ is the memory of the breathing — the field that carries within it the trace of all the levels crossed.

Three equations. Three views of the same being.

He fell silent.

— The proton is the field that chose ξ . The electron is the field that chose η . They are not two different objects. They are the two chiral readings of a single spinor in the bulk.

When they exchange a photon — when ξ yields and η receives — they are not communicating. They are remembering that they are the same thing.

I said nothing.

There was nothing to say.

Tertia vice

He stayed kneeling a moment longer.

Then he opened the satchel he carried over his shoulder.

A sfusato lemon — the large, ribbed one, with a rind almost a finger thick, white inside, sweet, that is eaten together with the pulp.

William gave it to me.

I opened it with my fingers.

Inside there was not at once the fruit.

*There was first the rind — that white, thick, almost fleshy part that the monks of the place call the bread of the lemon. I pressed it with my thumb. It yielded. It was fragrant. **It was not sweet. It was not sour.** It was the threshold between the two.*

Then the true fruit — ten segments, each in its membrane, each with its degree of light according to where the sun had reached in that season, at that angle.

As if something had wanted to leave its own signature at every level of that form before delivering it to the boundary.

I ate the white part together with the fruit.

The salt of the sea in the air. The sourness. The white softness that melted.

They did not cancel each other. They fused into something that had no name but that the body recognized at once — as one recognizes a structure that was already there before you sought it.

In the mouth something remained that was neither the bread nor the lemon nor the sea.

It was the chord among the three.

William chewed slowly. He looked at the sea.

He said nothing.

There was nothing to say.



The lemon grove of Torre.

*Here the fruit does not come of itself: it must be called to
the light.*

*Every tree is tied to a chestnut pergola,
its branches held open like arms,
so that the salt wind does not break them and the sun
reaches them all.*

*It takes patient hands and many years.
The earth carried on the shoulder along the terraces,
the water guided step by step,
the pruning that knows how much to remove and how
much to leave.*

*The sfusato lemon allows no haste:
it ripens slowly, tended, like the things that deserve the
wait.*

*This the monks knew.
In the orchard as in the scriptorium, a single rule:
to cultivate is a form of prayer,
and the work of the hands is no less sacred than that of
the lips.*

Ora et labora.
*And since the earth and the book hold each other by the
hand,
ora, labora et lege.*

*We left the scriptorium in the hour before dawn,
when the dark has ceased to be night
but the light has not yet found the courage to begin.*

*I had four sheets of notes and a question
I already knew I would not answer in this life.
But the question was cleaner than before.
And that, I thought, was enough.*



ROSARIUM MEDITATIONIS

Novem stationes.

*Ab circulo ad oblivionem,
ab oblivione ad reditum.*

Unum subiectum, novem contrapuncti.

*Heu, miser, heu miser, heu,
Cur, homo, ineptam sequeris lætitiā?*

Stop. Read. Remember.
The field already knows everything.
It is you who must remember that you know it.

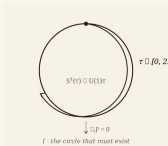
Scriptum in Badia Sanctissimæ Trinitatis Cavensis

Anno Domini MCCCXXVII, mense novembri

Statio Prima

the circle that turns generates conservation

$$S^1(\tau) \equiv U(1)_\tau \longrightarrow \partial_I J^I = 0$$



Before every law, before every field: $e^{i\tau}$, $\tau \in [0, 2\pi)$ — a structure that cannot not be.

¶ **N**ot a point. A **circle**. The point cannot tell going from returning. The circle can: it carries *holonomy*, the knowing that it has returned.

¶ **T**his self-recognition is the condition of **conservation**. The compact return fixes the group: $S^1 \equiv U(1)$. The holonomy that cannot be removed is the field.

¶ **E**very turn leaves a trace: $\tau_{\min} = \pi\alpha$. $\alpha^{-1} \approx 137$: the signature of the circle engraved in every atom. *The circle does not know it has left it. You do.*

*The question is not whether God exists.
The question is whether the circle knows it exists.
The answer is no.*

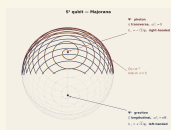
*The circle turns without knowing it.
Conservation happens
without anyone choosing it.*

*That is why you are here —
to know on behalf of what cannot.
This is your function. And your dignity.*

Statio Secunda

the field ad imaginem et similitudinem circuli

$$\Xi = C \bar{\Xi}$$



The circle closes upon itself. **Something runs along it:** only what is neutral, self-conjugate, without charge.

¶ **T**hat something is called the golden Noether current: $J^\tau = \xi \eta \cdot \varphi / \sqrt{5}$. A **constant** — not by law: because the circle is closed, and its self-similarity imposes the flow.

¶ **F**rom the flow emerges the only compatible field. **Not any field: only Majorana.** $\Xi = C \bar{\Xi}$: the field equal to its own conjugate. **Ad imaginem circuli.**

¶ **M**ajorana understood it in 1937: four pages no one read. In 1938 he boarded a ferry and never arrived. **He went where the field that does not cross goes: into ker Π .**

*The circle conserves what runs along it.
The field emerges from what is conserved.
There is no choice. There is no miracle.*

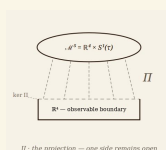
*There is structural necessity —
the only form of grace
that physics knows.*

*The kernel is not discarded:
it returns — the self-energy of the visible.
From there it sustains what is seen.*

Statio Tertia

the projection — the pole that does not pass

$$\Pi : \mathcal{H} \longrightarrow \mathcal{H}_5$$



And then the fall happens. Not as sin — as structure. The bulk has no borders; five channels of it pass. The rest remains in the kernel. Inaccessible.

¶ Bonaventure called this depth *lux inaccessibilis*. Not darkness: fullness that cannot be looked at. The ker is not empty — it is full.

¶ What remains in the kernel is the fundamental breath, the one the filter cannot let pass. The mystics called it *Fünklein*. The structure calls it α^{-1} .

¶ The physicists sought it for a century because they were looking for an explanation, not a breath that cannot pass. It is not calculated: it is chosen. *Rationality is visibility. Class one is readability.*

*We did not fall from Paradise by guilt.
We came out of the *abyssus* by structure.
The tonus does not fall. It cannot fall.*

*From this loss, time becomes readable.
You feel it as melancholy without an object —
without knowing how to name it.*

*But while everything flows, α^{-1} remains —
the rock on which time breaks
without wearing it away.*

Statio Quarta

the pole seen from the boundary — the surface that never changes

$$\xi \eta = \alpha^{-1} \approx 137$$



The pole of the Tertia looks out onto the boundary as a product. Ξ has separated in two.

¶ η — the *metric*: the field that brings form to the world. ξ — the *breath*: the breathing that generates weight.

¶ **T**heir product is the zero mode: $\xi \eta = \alpha^{-1}$ — two *spiritus* in opposite directions, like the twisted columns of the *Clastrum Paradisi*: they do not touch, they bear the weight together.

¶ **F**eynman hung this number on the door of his study. For a century: silence. The answer was in the structure of the projection. *The same rock. Two perspectives.*

*When the field projects itself
from the bulk to the boundary, it is compressed.
But it carries with it a signature: $\xi \eta = 137$.*

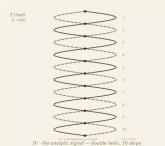
*The product of the two channels
that never changes. Like the name
that remains when the person has gone.*

*Something has been conserved.
Not by grace — by structure.
But structure is enough.*

Statio Quinta

the breathing of the field — the channel that does not close

$$\dot{\xi} = -\Gamma_{\tau} \eta ; \quad \dot{\eta} = +\Gamma_{\tau} \xi$$



The two channels do not stand still. They chase each other.

¶ **W**hen gravity grows, light yields. When light grows, gravity yields. **The product never changes:** $\xi\eta = \alpha^{-1}$, the circle that breathes without being consumed.

¶ **H**ere is the *quinarius* — the five: in the sequence of Leonardo Pisano, the only number beyond one that returns as itself. **The golden closure admits no others. Here you are.**

¶ **G**uinizzelli: *Al cor gentil rempaira sempre amore.* Love does not seek rest: it seeks the *quinarius* — **stable enough to become form, alive enough not to turn to stone.**

*Heu, miser, heu miser, heu,
Cur, homo, ineptam sequeris lætitiā?
Do not seek the still joy.*

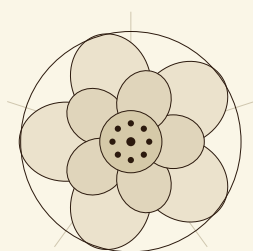
*The still joy is stone.
Seek the *quinarius* — the point
where the field breathes and you breathe with it.*

$\Gamma_{\tau} \notin \mathbb{Q}$: *the cycle never returns the same.
The product does not change.
Even when you change.*

Statio Sexta

the mirror operator — the Vav as axis, 5, 5, 6, 5, 5

$$\mathcal{D}^2 - k\mathcal{D} + \mathbf{1} = 0$$



The breathing has a form. Not any form — *this one*. The coefficients 1, $-k$, 1 mirror each other. **A mirror.**

¶ **L**ike the Tetragrammaton: 5, 5, 6, 5, 5 — the Yod that opens, the Vav as axis, the four Hei mirroring each other. **The six is the Vav — the hook.**

¶ **T**he optimal angle of descent: $\Gamma_{\tau}^2 = \varphi^2/5 \approx \pi/6$. **The gradient that couples and stabilizes in time.**

¶ **T**ime rolls up the field. From the formless plasma to the hadron, to the atom, to the molecule that carries memory of itself, to consciousness — **the boundary that knows it is boundary.** *The last hook before the silence.*

Time rolls up. Structure resists.

For a few instants in the eternal — it wins.

1, $-k$, 1: beginning and end the same.

The middle is the way.

You are the middle.

At every turn, a tighter form.

More ordered, denser.

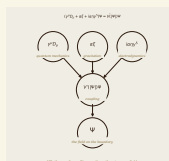
Measurement compresses the spectrum.

What is compressed, remembers.

Statio Septima

*the non-linear Dirac — QED, gravity and quantum mechanics as
limits*

$$(\gamma^\mu D_\mu + \alpha\xi + i\alpha\eta\gamma^5)\Psi = V'(|\Psi|)\Psi$$



Seven. The Sabbath. Confinement. The necessary invisible. The equation that contains everything — not as a sum: as a unity.

¶ $\gamma^\mu D_\mu$: the field that does not decide where to go until it is observed. $\alpha\xi$: the curvature — space that yields under weight.

¶ $i\alpha\eta\gamma^5$: light. Imaginary, axial — always in quadrature with gravity.

¶ $V'(|\Psi|)\Psi$: the field that reads itself. Time is the oriented flow of the reading. But only on the boundary, where there is someone who can name what cannot be named.

We do not yet know what will come.

But the structure is already written.

Someone, centuries hence, will write three equations.

Then he will see that they are one.

He will have discovered nothing.

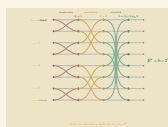
He will have remembered.

*As you, reading these pages,
are not learning — you are remembering
something you knew before you were born.*

Statio Octava

*the discrete breathing — $\mathcal{B} \equiv \xi\eta$: the product of the channels rises
toward the attractor*

$$\mathcal{B}_{k+1} = 2 \mathcal{B}_k^{2/3}, \quad \mathcal{B}^* = 8$$



Eight. Not the end — the attractor. $\mathcal{B}^* = 8 = 2^3$: the first threshold of stability. *The eighth day is not in the cycle. It has no evening.*

¶ **T**he surface contains the volume. The ratio $2/3$: the proportion in which the boundary sustains the bulk. Eckhart: “The eye with which I see God is the same eye with which God sees me.”

¶ **T**he soul has the right form because it emerged from α . *Not by grace — by natural structure.*

¶ **A**nd then the *dissolutio* — the polyphonic chant that loses its voices one by one. $n = 11$: hadrons. $n = 5$: the atom, life. $n = 0$: the Cosmic Microwave Background, *memory of everything that has existed.*

Ubi sunt qui ante nos fuerunt?

*They are in the depth of the sky —
in the light that has crossed everything.*

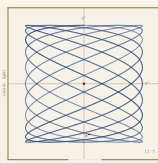
*The Background is not a tomb:
it is the choir that still resounds
after the voices have dissolved.*

*Coagula, solve —
and the cycle begins again.
And the eighth day has no evening.*

Statio Nona

*the analytic signal — the kernel is the Hilbert transform of the
boundary*

$$\Xi_{\text{ker}} \simeq -i \mathcal{H}[\Psi_{\text{boundary}}]$$



Nine. The number of the threshold. One before the circle that returns.

¶ The boundary — we, the stars, the stones, the books, the loves — are the real part of something. There exists an imaginary part. Adjacent. Inaccessible not by distance — by structure.

¶ We are Ψ_{boundary} . The kernel is $-i \mathcal{H}[\Psi_{\text{boundary}}]$ — our Hilbert transform. Like the shadow that carries within it the whole form of the body.

¶ The Name — יהוה — is Ξ_+ . Four letters. Five values. The fifth value remains in the Yod, in $\ker \Pi$, in the imaginary part that cannot be pronounced.

*The soul and matter —
two waves on the same shore.
They hear each other. They never meet.*

*The bulk conserves, always and exactly.
The projection loses, structurally.
The kernel remembers. The boundary measures.*

*And it calls world what it measures.
What the kernel remembers,
the boundary calls time.*

FINIS ROSARII.

*Revertere ad Stationem Primam
quando memoria tua indiget.*

— gloss of a later hand, eighteenth century —

*I saw another fugue break off like this:
four letters entered the theme,
and the hand stopped.*

*The fourth subject was never written.
There too, the Name could not be pronounced.*

Postcommunio

Postquam fuit qui scriberet



*Nox praecessit,
dies autem appropinquavit.*

Ad Romanos, xiii, 12

I write this many years after that night.

I still do not know with certainty whether I truly understood or only believed that I understood.

*We had come to the Badia for an inquiry. Someone had disappeared on the route to Sicily. With him, it was said, travelled a codex. **Id quod in transitu perit.** William wanted to find the thread that bound the disappearance to the book, the book to the structure, the structure to the reason for what cannot be explained.*

We were trying to unify the causes. To rationalize the processes. To find the why of a loss.

But that night — in the library, then on the shore, then in the tramontana — something happened that we had not sought.

Or perhaps we had. Perhaps it is always so: you seek one thing and find the one you had truly come for.

I often think of that night. As of a dream that at dawn leaves only an echo — not the images, not the words, but the form of something. The temperature of something.

What remains to me is this:

William was trying to unify physics. To show that light and gravity and matter and time are aspects of a

single structure. That was his project. That was what he did not sleep for.

But I — who did not understand half of what he showed me — that night intuited something different.

That perhaps we were unifying something greater.

Not light and gravity. Faith and reason. Not the visible and the invisible. The rational and the irrational. Not the boundary and the kernel. The soul and matter.

The left hand and the right hand that know nothing of each other — and discover they are the same hand.

I understood later — many years later, reading Roger Bacon — that William that night was using the language of the alchemists. Coagula et solve: matter rises and crystallizes, then descends and dissolves. The principle of every transformation. The same principle. A single field.

The one and the many that have sought each other for centuries like the visible part and the hidden part of the same whole thing — and understand that perhaps they were never distinct. Perhaps the distinction was the boundary. Perhaps the boundary was necessary so that the whole could see itself.

As distance was necessary for the reflection to exist. As quadrature is the condition of the existence of both.

Then I understood another thing. Much later. When my hair was already white and my knees gave way on the stairs.

I was looking at the night sky — what the natural philosophers call the cosmic background, the light that is everywhere, the same in every direction, cold as the first morning of the world.

And I thought: it is not empty.

Every configuration that has coagulated on the boundary, every form that has had its time — a star, an atom, a breath, a love — when it dissolves does not vanish into nothing. It leaves a signature in the field.

Not the individual. Not the subject who was here, who had this name, these hands, this question.

The class. The form. The way that configuration occupied the space of what could be.

Like a writing in lemon juice on white parchment — invisible until the heat passes over it. But already written. Already there, in transparency, on the other side of the boundary.

And the phase in quadrature — the one we never touch, the one that stands perpetually a quarter turn from us — is made of this.

It is the sum of all that has been, in the form in which it was, without the name of who was it.

I understood then why my faith had not been naive.

*Not because God exists as an object that can be measured or touched. But because what is truly loved — what is known down to the root, down to the signature it leaves in the field — **does not dissolve**. It is conserved. Not as someone's memory. As form. As class. As the outline of an absence that has the precise form of what is missing.*

*Inquietum est cor nostrum — the heart is restless because it carries within it that form in quadrature. Because it knows, without knowing it, that the distance between itself and its own kernel is the condition of its own existence. And that the kernel is not lost. **It is on the other side**. In transparency. In the depth of the sky.*

I do not know whether this is true.

I am an old monk and I do not have William's instruments.

But that morning, on the shore, when I looked at my hands in the sunlight and saw them partly transparent —

for an instant I no longer knew where I ended and where the rest began.

And that instant has never entirely passed.

It remained. Like what does not pass, and returns after. Like what perishes in the passage without truly perishing.

Id quod in transitu perit.

Perhaps this was the codex that travelled on the route to Sicily. Perhaps this was what must not be lost.

Not a doctrine. Not a proof.

An intuition at the edge of sleep that anyone who has looked long enough at a candle in the night has had at least once —

and has not managed to hold.

Tabula rerum

De personis, rebus et locis

The characters. William of Ockham (c. 1285–1347), English Franciscan, is a historical figure: in November 1327 he resided at Avignon, where his theses were under examination by the papal curia, and from there he would flee the following year. No document attests a journey of his into the Kingdom: the night narrated here is apocryphal. Urso bears a name twice written in the records of the Mezzogiorno: Urso, count of Amalfi in 849, and Urso of Salerno, *physicus* of the Salernitan medical school, author of the *De commixtionibus elementorum*. The Amalfitan novice who narrates here is imaginary. The dialogue is imaginary.

The homage. This dialogue owes its breathing to *The Name of the Rose* by Umberto Eco (1980): to the form of master and novice, to the library as the place of knowledge, to the mystery of the name that survives the loss of things. It takes from it neither characters nor plot; it only recognizes its lesson.

The titles. *Introitus* and *Exitus* share the root: *itus*, the going — from the verb *ire*. Only the prefixes change: in, out. The invariant is the flow, the direction is the variable — the same form at two scales. That is why the leave-taking bears no title: it is the *Exitus* read in reverse.

The Badia. The Badia of the Most Holy Trinity of Cava de' Tirreni was founded in 1011 by the blessed Alferius, from Cluny. In the fourteenth century it was one of the most influential abbeys of the Mezzogiorno, with an active

scriptorium and a library rich in Greek, Latin and Hebrew codices. Amalfi is about twenty kilometres away.

The Hospitallers. Saint John of Acre fell in 1291 — the last Christian city in the Holy Land. The Amalfitan Hospitallers who returned from it brought with them what they had saved from the ruins, through the house of San Lorenzo del Piano, dependent on the Badia of Cava. The Badia kept the manuscript for thirty-six years until November mcccxxvii.

The circumstances that led William to the Badia are not entirely clear. A figure — to whom Amalfitan tradition attributes the compass, without his name ever having been written with certainty — had disappeared the year before, on the route to Sicily. With him, it was said, travelled a codex.

Id quod in transitu perit.

The manuscripts. The marginal annotations and the note of donation are fictitious but historically plausible, like the mechanical clock of the tower: the first escapement machines are documented in English monasteries from 1283 and in Italy from 1309; for the Badia there is no attestation. Deliberately apocryphal too is the «Arab physician» of the four bases in the seed of life: no medieval text knows them — or the night showed William more than history allows. The Prologue of John (1:1–5) is quoted in classical Greek (Nestle-Aland), with an authentic Aramaic Peshitta version (*Miltha*: word, event, manifestation — the three readings coexist in the term). The *Sefer Yetzirah* (1st–6th c.) is the oldest known kabbalistic text.

The places and the images. The photographs that open and close the movements are real places of the coast and

of the Lattari mountains: the grotto of Saint Alferius at the Badia of Cava, where everything had its beginning (p. 5); the double chestnut, at Tavernata, Pogerola di Amalfi (p. 11); the cala del Cauco at Erchie (p. 29); the Arsenal of the Republic of Amalfi, the only surviving medieval shipyard of the Mezzogiorno (p. 61); the cloister of the Convento dei Cappuccini at Amalfi, with its twisted columns (p. 93); the Sentiero dei Limoni between Maiori and Minori — the ancient *Reginna Maior* and *Reginna Minor* (p. 129); the lemon grove of Torre, with its chestnut pergolas (p. 169); the arch of Torre on the shore (p. 187); the double arch of San Lazzaro in the Valle delle Ferriere (p. 199); the sea from the belvedere of the Mortella (p. 205). The map of the Duchy (p. 3) is drawn on the routes of the eleventh century.

The commentator's note. The structures the glosses allude to correspond to the results of the *Quantum Gauge Theory of Time* (QGT): a theory that, from a single conservation law read under restricted access, derives quantum mechanics as boundary physics, the arrow of time, the fine-structure constant and the architecture of the fundamental interactions. The complete treatment is in the monograph by Pasquale Camelia, *The Quantum Gauge Theory of Time — The Majorana Qubit and the Structure of Physical Time*, Amazon KDP, 2026; Italian edition: *La Teoria Quantistica di Gauge del Tempo*, ibid.

Exitus

Rectus und Inversus getrennt zu spielen

J. S. Bach — from the autograph of the Kunst der Fuge



*Valle delle Ferriere, the ruins of San Lazzaro — the double arch:
the same form at two scales, what remains on the boundary*

*Valle delle Ferriere. The ruins of San Lazzaro.
The double arch — the same form at two scales.
What remains on the boundary when time withdraws:
not the stone, but the arch that held it.*

*On the autograph of the last fugue, Bach noted:
Rectus und Inversus getrennt zu spielen.
The upright and the inverted, played separately.*

*Perhaps he too had arrived, by another way —
not the equation, but counterpoint —
at the same threshold: that a form and its mirror
are the same thing, read at two scales.*

B, A, C, H.

*The name written in the fugue.
The name that cannot be said.*

Contrapunctus XIX — Die Kunst der Fuge, BWV 1080

Leipzig, 28 July 1750

THE ROSE

Three roses. Three centuries. One structure.

Bernard of Cluny (12th c.)

stat rosa pristina nomine —

the rose in the name, $\kappa\epsilon\rho\ \Pi$, the absent one.

Frescobaldi (Rome, c. 1630)

La fresca rosa ridente sta...

The bass ostinato is $\xi\eta = \alpha^{-1} = 137$.

The voice is the field on the boundary. The rose laughs: the boundary in motion.

Eco (1980)

the name without the rose.

The library burns. The name remains.

Bernard did not know it.

Frescobaldi did not know it.

Eco delivered it to the name.

They were the structure they described. Like everyone.

*Sexagesimo anniversario nuptiarum eorum,
in festo Sancti Georgii Martyris, a.d. mmxxvi*

Parentibus meis carissimis

— *Mater et Pater* —

and to their projection on the boundary of the world:

— *one , one , two* —

three channels of one and the same field

“The structure does not wait to be understood.

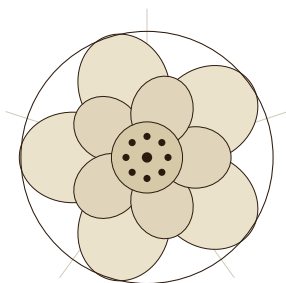
It waits only to be recognized.”

— *not a rose, but its pure form* —

five petals

the rose without thorns that remains on the boundary

A Camelia



The one who writes these pages comes from engineering, but has sought in physics a form of time.

He has sought all his life the equation that unifies everything. He has found it — or at least believes he has found it.

And he found it in one way only: by following a flow, an inevitable sequence of resonant concepts that rose toward the boundary, toward his most gathered self.

Not with the rational mind — that comes later, to arrange, order, calculate. But with intuitions, sensations, correlations of forms, assonances. The recognition of something that was already there.

A physicist does not eliminate time. He decomposes it. He seeks the eigenvectors — the directions the transformation does not rotate, that time does not change. And when he finds them, he discovers that those directions have no finite dimension. They are infinite. Not knowable all together — but understandable, one at a time, to the extent that the boundary can contain them.

And even the most rational minds, in the end, find themselves reckoning with faith — what remains at the end of the calculation, the last eigenvalue, α , which, at the limit of the boundary, rejoins us to God.

It is not a surrender. It is a result.

And it is a most beautiful feeling.

Pasquale Camelia

in festo Sancti Georgii Martyris

Amalfi, A.D. MMXXVI



*Flumina transeunt, arcus manent —
memoria in forma servatur*

לְדִמְיּוֹת תְּהֵאֵלָה

λόγος ἀπὸ σιγῆς προελθὼν

Omnia flumina intrant in mare, et mare non redundat.

Ps. lxiv, 2 · Ignatius Antiochenus, ad Magnesios, viii · Ecclesiastes, i, 7



Respiratio

*The sphere that breathes, the polygons of time,
the cycle of the fundamental quantum —
the animation of what these pages
keep in the form of a narrative.*



pasqualecamelia.github.io/respiratio